



Prepare and submit quotations

D2.TCS.CL5.20

D2.TTA.CL2.16

Trainee Manual



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William
Angliss
Institute

Specialist centre
for foods, tourism
& hospitality

Project Base

William Angliss Institute of TAFE

555 La Trobe Street

Melbourne 3000 Victoria

Telephone: (03) 9606 2111

Facsimile: (03) 9670 1330

Acknowledgements

Project Director: Wayne Crosbie

Project Manager: Jim Irwin

Chief Writer: Alan Hickman

Subject Writer: Nick Hyland

Editor: Jim Irwin

DTP/Production: Daniel Chee, Mai Vu, Cindy Curran

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Introduction to trainee manual

To the Trainee

Congratulations on joining this course. This Trainee Manual is one part of a 'toolbox' which is a resource provided to trainees, trainers and assessors to help you become competent in various areas of your work.

The 'toolbox' consists of three elements:

- A Trainee Manual for you to read and study at home or in class
- A Trainer Guide with Power Point slides to help your Trainer explain the content of the training material and provide class activities to help with practice
- An Assessment Manual which provides your Assessor with oral and written questions and other assessment tasks to establish whether or not you have achieved competency.

The first thing you may notice is that this training program and the information you find in the Trainee Manual seems different to the textbooks you have used previously. This is because the method of instruction and examination is different. The method used is called Competency based training (CBT) and Competency based assessment (CBA). CBT and CBA is the training and assessment system chosen by ASEAN (Association of South-East Asian Nations) to train people to work in the tourism and hospitality industry throughout all the ASEAN member states.

What is the CBT and CBA system and why has it been adopted by ASEAN?

CBT is a way of training that concentrates on what a worker can do or is required to do at work. The aim of the training is to enable trainees to perform tasks and duties at a standard expected by employers. CBT seeks to develop the skills, knowledge and attitudes (or recognise the ones the trainee already possesses) to achieve the required competency standard. ASEAN has adopted the CBT/CBA training system as it is able to produce the type of worker that industry is looking for and this therefore increases trainees chances of obtaining employment.

CBA involves collecting evidence and making a judgement of the extent to which a worker can perform his/her duties at the required competency standard. Where a trainee can already demonstrate a degree of competency, either due to prior training or work experience, a process of 'Recognition of Prior Learning' (RPL) is available to trainees to recognise this. Please speak to your trainer about RPL if you think this applies to you.

What is a competency standard?

Competency standards are descriptions of the skills and knowledge required to perform a task or activity at the level of a required standard.

242 competency standards for the tourism and hospitality industries throughout the ASEAN region have been developed to cover all the knowledge, skills and attitudes required to work in the following occupational areas:

- Housekeeping
- Food Production
- Food and Beverage Service
- Front Office

- Travel Agencies
- Tour Operations.

All of these competency standards are available for you to look at. In fact you will find a summary of each one at the beginning of each Trainee Manual under the heading 'Unit Descriptor'. The unit descriptor describes the content of the unit you will be studying in the Trainee Manual and provides a table of contents which are divided up into 'Elements' and 'Performance Criteria'. An element is a description of one aspect of what has to be achieved in the workplace. The 'Performance Criteria' below each element details the level of performance that needs to be demonstrated to be declared competent.

There are other components of the competency standard:

- *Unit Title*: statement about what is to be done in the workplace
- *Unit Number*: unique number identifying the particular competency
- *Nominal hours*: number of classroom or practical hours usually needed to complete the competency. We call them 'nominal' hours because they can vary e.g. sometimes it will take an individual less time to complete a unit of competency because he/she has prior knowledge or work experience in that area.

The final heading you will see before you start reading the Trainee Manual is the 'Assessment Matrix'. Competency based assessment requires trainees to be assessed in at least 2 – 3 different ways, one of which must be practical. This section outlines three ways assessment can be carried out and includes work projects, written questions and oral questions. The matrix is designed to show you which performance criteria will be assessed and how they will be assessed. Your trainer and/or assessor may also use other assessment methods including 'Observation Checklist' and 'Third Party Statement'. An observation checklist is a way of recording how you perform at work and a third party statement is a statement by a supervisor or employer about the degree of competence they believe you have achieved. This can be based on observing your workplace performance, inspecting your work or gaining feedback from fellow workers.

Your trainer and/or assessor may use other methods to assess you such as:

- Journals
- Oral presentations
- Role plays
- Log books
- Group projects
- Practical demonstrations.

Remember your trainer is there to help you succeed and become competent. Please feel free to ask him or her for more explanation of what you have just read and of what is expected from you and best wishes for your future studies and future career in tourism and hospitality.

Unit descriptor

Prepare and submit quotations

This unit deals with the skills and knowledge required to Prepare and submit quotations in a range of settings within the travel industries workplace context.

Unit Code:

D2.TCS.CL5.20

D2.TTA.CL2.16

Nominal Hours:

40

Element 1: Identify the context for the quotation

Performance Criteria

- 1.1 Identify the focus for quotations
- 1.2 Identify the details for the quotation

Element 2: Prepare the quotation

Performance Criteria

- 2.1 Establish files to record the quotation
- 2.2 Identify appropriate supplier and provider alternatives
- 2.3 Calculate costs of products and services required for the quotation
- 2.4 Identify terms and conditions that apply to the quotation
- 2.5 Submit draft quotation for approval
- 2.6 Amend draft quotation, as required
- 2.7 Record and file the approved quotation

Element 3: Submit the quotation

Performance Criteria

- 3.1 Identify the required submission method
- 3.2 Provide the quotation
- 3.3 Explain and expand on the quotation
- 3.4 Encourage questions from the client
- 3.5 Advise client of action to make booking

Element 4: Follow-up the quotation

Performance Criteria

- 4.1 Advise client of any changes that will affect the provided quotation
- 4.2 Provide additional advice and assistance, as requested
- 4.3 Maintain contact with the client
- 4.4 Implement actions to close the sale
- 4.5 Record changes to, and communications, regarding the quotation

Assessment matrix

Showing mapping of Performance Criteria against Work Projects, Written Questions and Oral Questions

The Assessment Matrix indicates three of the most common assessment activities your Assessor may use to assess your understanding of the content of this manual and your performance - Work Projects, Written Questions and Oral Questions. It also indicates where you can find the subject content related to these assessment activities in the Trainee Manual (i.e. under which element or performance criteria). As explained in the Introduction, however, the assessors are free to choose which assessment activities are most suitable to best capture evidence of competency as they deem appropriate for individual students.

		Work Projects	Written Questions	Oral Questions
Element 1: Identify the context for the quotation				
1.1	Identify the focus for quotations	1.1	1,2	1,2
1.2	Identify the details for the quotation	1.2	3	3
Element 2: Prepare the quotation				
2.1	Establish files to record the quotation	2.1	4	4
2.2	Identify appropriate supplier and provider alternatives	2.2	5	5
2.3	Calculate costs of products and services required for the quotation	2.3	6	6
2.4	Identify terms and conditions that apply to the quotation	2.4	7	7
2.5	Submit draft quotation for approval	2.5	8	8
2.6	Amend draft quotation, as required	2.6	9	9
2.7	Record and file the approved quotation	2.7	10	10
Element 3: Submit the quotation				
3.1	Identify the required submission method	3.1	11	11
3.2	Provide the quotation	3.2	12	12
3.3	Explain and expand on the quotation	3.3	13	13
3.4	Encourage questions from the client	3.4	14	14
3.5	Advise client of action to make booking	3.5	15	15

		Work Projects	Written Questions	Oral Questions
Element 4: Follow-up the quotation				
4.1	Advise client of any changes that will affect the provided quotation	4.1	16	16
4.2	Provide additional advice and assistance, as requested	4.2	17	17
4.3	Maintain contact with the client	4.3	18	18
4.4	Implement actions to close the sale	4.4	19	19
4.5	Record changes to, and communications, regarding the quotation	4.5	20	20

Glossary

Term	Explanation
Auxiliary	Additional products and services appropriate and used to enhance another product or service
BDM	Business Development Manager
Blog	A website containing a writer's or group of writers' own experiences, observations, opinions, etc., and often having images and links to other websites.
Client	Customer or person responsible for arranging travel for another.
Colleague	A fellow worker or member of a staff, department, profession
Communication	The imparting or interchange of thoughts, opinions, or information by speech, writing, or signs
Consultation	Seeking input, advice and suggestions from others
CRS	Central Reservation System
Data	Piece of travel related information
Document	Any paper or electronic form of ticket, voucher or travel related information
Dossier	Document containing all the detailed information regarding a travel activity
Efficiency	How well something is done with effective use of resources
Enterprise	Organisation or business
E-ticket	Electronic ticket
ETA	Estimated time of arrival
ETD	Estimated time of departure
GDS	Global Distribution System
Inbound	Travellers coming into a country

Term	Explanation
Kitty	Actual cash, often in small denominations used for purchases. Also known as a float.
Mark-up	Profit margin identified by difference between price quoted to customer and that quoted by suppliers
Merchant Fee	Fee charges by credit card company
Non-air	Any travel that is land or sea based
Nett	Financial amount after direct expenses or taxes have been deducted
Network	Gathering of people for a particular purpose
Outbound	Travellers leaving a country
PDS	Product Disclosure Statement
Preferences	Experience your customer is seeking
Preferred agreement	A formal commercial agreement between a supplier and a travel agent which facilitates the payment of extra commission and other benefits by the supplier to the travel agent in exchange for the travel agents agreement to sell the suppliers product.
Press	Any form of public media
Pro-forma	Template used to collect or record information in a structured and set way.
Quotation	A statement of information and prices relating to travel activity
Supplier	Also known as operator. Any organisation that provides travel related products or services.
Tariffs	Prices
TIM	Travel Information Manual
Transfers	Method of transportation used of getting from one destination to another
Wholesaler	Travel organisation that packages different supplier services

Element 1:

Identify the context for the quotation

1.1 Identify the focus for quotations

Introduction

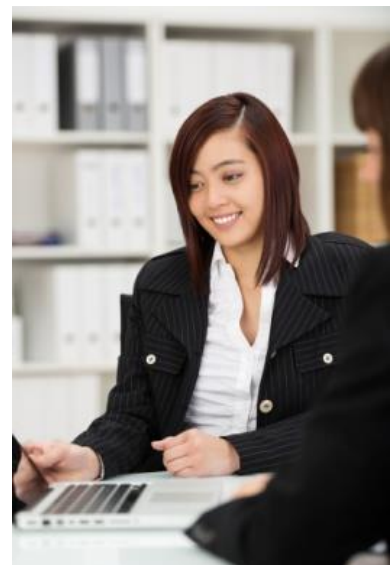
A quotation is a summary of costs for products and services which are provided by the travel agent to potential customers who wish to travel, either within a specific country or overseas and who are considering purchasing these products and services from your travel organisation.

Ways to receive requests for quotations

A request for the provision of a quotation is usually received by the travel professional in one of the following ways:

- Face to face consultation
- Verbal
- Written.

Key to the provision of a quotation is the use of good communication skills in order to assemble and record all the necessary facts and information needed to provide a quotation.



Focus audience of quotations

Quotations may be prepared using manual or electronic or automated systems and can be prepared for:

Single or multiple products and services:

- Groups or individuals
- One-off arrangements or a series of arrangements
- Tours, trips, travel and transfers
- Accommodation, meals and entertainment
- Guiding services
- Entry to attractions
- Venue and equipment hire
- Meetings, events, functions and conferences.



1.2 Identify the details for the quotation

Introduction

Naturally before any quotation can be taken, it is important to:

- Collect customer personal information
- Identify the needs of the customer.

By collecting relevant information, travel agents can accurately source the most desirable products and services that can be included in a quotation, to reflect their travel needs.

Seek customer personal information

The standard information contained within these documents is as follows:

- Name, initial and title
- Dates of birth for passengers, in particular children
- Contact details for home, work and mobiles
- Special meal requests or seating preferences
- Frequent flyer information and club memberships
- Details of travel such as dates, places and products
- Payment details
- Wholesaler or Consolidator used.



Identify customer travel details and requirements

Details for the quotation may be related to:

- Name and contact details of the client including details of the traveller where the contact is not the user
- Proposed itinerary, including destinations (intermediary and final destinations), services and activities required, attractions to be visited
- Accommodation and dining/catering requirements
- Budget
- Dates and times, including specific days, seasonal imperatives and duration
- Customer numbers and classification, including adults, children, babies and groups
- Preferred travel options, including destination travel requirements
- Reasons for trip, function
- Non-negotiable elements that relate to the quotation
- Previous history of the client in relation to bookings made.



Work Projects

CASE STUDY

All work projects for this subject are based around the following case study.

A customer has come to your travel company, requesting a business trip to be arranged for three persons in his organisation.

The travelling party consists of:

- Mr Peter Smith (himself) – Australian passport holder
- Mrs Ann Rogers (his colleague) – British passport holder
- Mr Ray White (his colleague) – South African passport holder.

They have different passports and therefore may have visa requirements, given the purpose of their trip is 'for business meetings'.

Company details are as follows:

ASEAN Corporation

15 Jalan Stesen Sentral
Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia 50470

P) 60-3-2264-2100

E) p.smith@asean.com

You can use your own personal details (address, phone, email, etc.) as a reference for his personal details.

Proposed itinerary

- They are travelling from and returning to Kuala Lumpur
- They have a proposed itinerary that is as follows:

DAY	PROPOSED ACTIVITIES
Monday	AM Flight Kuala Lumpur to Singapore
Tuesday	AM Meetings in central Singapore PM Recreational Activity
Wednesday	AM Flight Singapore to Bangkok PM Meetings in central Bangkok
Thursday	AM Flight from Bangkok to Ho Chi Minh City PM Recreational Activity
Friday	AM Meetings in central Ho Chi Minh City PM Flight Ho Chi Minh City to Kuala Lumpur

Quotation Requests

He has requested the following information:

- The dates of the travel are to be determined by the travel company, but they must be from Monday to Friday
- They are to fly economy class
- They must have separate hotel rooms
- The hotels must be centrally located and be a minimum of '4 stars'
- Hotel rates must include breakfast. Their budget is USD\$300 per night including taxes and breakfast
- A meeting room must be arranged for meetings at the hotel in which they are staying. They need a boardroom for 10 people including catering (tea, coffee, biscuits) for three hours. No electronic equipment is required in the meeting rooms
- Transportation to/from all airports required. Hotel car preferable. In Kuala Lumpur transport options must be provided to/from airport from their office
- Any times stipulated as Recreational Activity is free for the travel agent to make suggestions and to provide costings. They are looking for general sightseeing with some opportunities for shopping to be included in one of the activities
- Suggested dining establishments for dinner in Singapore, Bangkok and Ho Chi Minh City is required. They are looking for a 'local culinary experience' and have a budget of USD\$40 each, per meal period, for food only
- The company will pay for all expenses using one American Express Corporate Credit Card
- Any further information relating to the travel can be reflected in your own personal details or recommendations
- All prices must be quoted in United States Dollars (USD\$)
- As a travel agent, you are to mark up all costs by 3% as a profit margin.



Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

These Work Project Activities are based on the Case Study as previously identified.

1.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- Ways in which quotations may be received from the customer.

1.2. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- Key details as received from the customer
 - Identify details that appear to be missing that must be clarified.
-

Summary

Identify the context for the quotation

Identify the focus for quotations

- Ways to receive requests for quotations
- Focus audience of quotations.

Identify the details for the quotation

- Seek customer personal information
- Identify customer travel details and requirements.

Element 2:

Prepare the quotation

2.1 Establish files to record the quotation

Introduction

Most travel agencies will use a combination recording system to record:

- Customer detail
- Supplier quotations
- Travel agency quotations.

Regardless of the recording method used, it is essential that all information is recorded in a thorough and accurate manner.

Given that many travel agencies receive many requests for quotations and in addition are required to produce quotations, it is essential that the recording method chosen enables any travel agent staff member, regardless of previous contact with customers, are able to understand:

- Customer requirements
- Information sourced to date
- Information provided to customers to date
- Communication discussions taken place to date.

Most travel organisations require staff to record notes using only jargon that is generic and that can be understood by the entire team.

In addition, to ensure that staff endeavour to be disciplined in the way they record any information collected or discussed with customers and suppliers at the time that they take place.



Process of collecting customer information and travel needs

Before we look at possible methods of recording information for quotations, it is important to briefly understand the process involved in collecting information and preparing quotations for customers.

Here is an example of a typical process:

- Initial customer contact – notes taken using a pro-forma quotation planner or enquiry sheet
- Quotation reference number allocated using internal office protocol – Manual or Electronic
- Follow-up quotation work with suppliers – notes added to pro-forma quotation planner, enquiry sheet – Manual or Electronic
- Copies of correspondence from suppliers – Printed and placed in file or saved electronically
- Copies of correspondence to customer – Printed and placed in file or saved electronically
- Calendar book or diarise for follow-up – with suppliers or customer.



Methods to prepare quotations

There are two primary ways in which a travel organization agent will record and administer a customer's details and requirements in relation to the provision of a quotation:

- Electronic – a computer record
- Manual – a hand written record.

In both instances, most organisations will have a recommended format or input process for the collection and recording of this information.

All information relating to the quotation must be recorded regardless of the type of system used i.e. manual or electronic.

Importance of recording accurate information

It is important that these records be accurately maintained to ensure:

- Efficiency – when referring to the quote
- Effectiveness – when making reservations or changes with suppliers
- Team work – colleagues may need to refer to the quote in your absence
- Profitability – mistakes cost money
- Enhanced customer service.



Benefits of accurately recording information

If you are inundated with requests for quotations it may be possible to:

- Review and prioritise in order of importance
- Second one of your colleagues to assist you
- Reset agreed deadlines with customers
- Bring your situation to the attention of your manager or supervisor.

If you have followed a process of accurately and legibly recording all aspects of the quotation, it will be easy for your manager or colleagues to provide you with assistance.

Use of industry codes

Industry codes are used throughout, to denote the products and services requested, which makes it quick and easy to record information.

Examples are:

- Airport codes
- Airline codes
- Tour codes
- Room types
- Service codes.



There are many software packages that are used by travel agents which allow quick and easy access to quotations and an update notepad facility e.g. Cross Check Travel.

If you are provisionally holding airline seats, pending acceptance of the quotation by the customer, you may elect to use the notepad facility in the CRS to record information in relation to fares, taxes etc.

Often the volume of quotations that travel agents are required to handle may mean that, at times, they are tempted to take short-cuts or skip some of the recommend steps in the recording process of providing a quotation. This is not advisable and invariably results in errors being made.

Using a Quotation Planner



Each organisation will have established pro-formas or documents which must be used by staff when collecting information from customers in which quotations can be based around.

The use of scraps of paper and posits are not advisable, for obvious reasons. A standard enquiry form is recommended to ensure that the correct questions are asked and that vital information is not forgotten.

Here is an example of a form that will assist in the collection and recording of the information required to provide a quotation.

QUOTATION PLANNER – TEMPLATE**General Information**

Consultant	
Date	
Contact name	
Telephone	
Mobile	
Email	
Destination	

Passenger/s

Surname	First Name	Title	DOB

General Questions

How many people will be travelling?

What type of holiday and/or destination do you have in mind?

When do you want to travel?

How long do you want to be away?

Where did you go on your last holiday?

What standard of accommodation are you looking for?

How much are you considering spending?

Are you a member of any frequent flyer programmes?

Rooming/cabin type required?

Preferred departure/return points?

Do you have any special requirements?

Is your passport valid?

What is the nationality of your passport?

Flight preferences

Dept Date	Origin	Destination	Airline	ETD/ETA	Costing

Land preferences

Arr Date	Dept Date	Accommodation/Ship/Tour	Room Type	No.	Costing

Checklist

Travel insurance	
Passport details	
Visa	
Schedule of fees	
Merchant fees	
Foreign currency	
Other	

Follow-up

Date quote provided	
1. Call back date/time	
2. Call back/date/time	

Quotation formats

In the previous example, a template has been identified to collect vital customer information and their travel needs.

In addition to having templates and guidelines when collecting information, travel companies will also have established formats when providing quotations to customers as well.

Every travel company will have their own guidelines regarding the provision of quotations to customers and you will need to work within the applicable and particular business procedures. Providing a quotation can be quick and easy or quite time consuming.

For complex itineraries requiring a lot of work, a formal written itinerary and quotation will be provided. Some businesses will charge an itinerary planning fee for this service. Basic and straight forward quotations e.g. a tour and an airfare will take less time and an approximate amount can often be provided on the spot.

These quotes are provided either formally in writing using a software program or informally on the back of a business card or on a 'with compliments' slip.



Customers will invariably shop around and in many instances you may not be the only travel agent being asked to provide a quotation. There are travel agents who offer to 'beat any price' or 'price match' any quotation. The provision of an informal quote, initially, will often make it challenging for another agent to decipher exactly what they are trying to beat or match. It is recommended that when engaging in 'price beat' or 'price match' activities that you are completely satisfied that you are dealing with apples and apples and not apples and oranges. Failure to do so will impact your bottom line.

Inclusions in formal quotations

The most formal quotation would be a combination of a letter stating all costs with a detailed itinerary of times, dates etc.

This letter would include the following information:

- Date of quotation and reference number (if applicable)
- Clients name
- Phone contacts and fax (if applicable)
- Email address
- Address
- Month of travel
- Length of travel and class of travel
- Flight details – at least two airlines including routing, stopovers, prices and taxes, special offers
- Tours



- Accommodation
- Transfers
- Inclusions and exclusions
- Insurance details
- Payment requirements and cancellation fees
- Conditions of the quote
- Deposits required
- Service fees
- Expiry date of the quotation
- General conditions and rules.



2.2 Identify appropriate supplier and provider alternatives

Introduction

Sourcing and selecting product and services to provide a quotation for your customer is reliant on your industry knowledge of what is possible.

It is also based on:

- Availability of appropriate products and services to suit the stated or established customer needs
- Suitable suppliers or wholesalers that can provide these products
- Prices that meet the passengers budget.



Importance of collecting information on different suppliers, products and services

Information is a key component of sales and marketing in tourism. Effective information is also a key requirement for the booking and documentation of any tourism product or service. Finding information and using it effectively to meet the needs of your customers is a key element of working in many tourism industry positions.

- Where is it?
- How do I get it?
- How long does it take?
- What is it like?
- Is there a good?
- How much does it cost?
- What would you recommend?
- What is the weather like?



- Where can I go to buy?

To assist customers, coordinate the booking and to ensure specific needs are met it is imperative to continually seek knowledge and updates on all products and services offered in the tourism industry.

One of the most important aspects of any job in the tourism industry is finding information. It is impossible to know everything about the thousands of different tourism products and services.

You can, with experience, build up what you know, and first-hand knowledge is the most valuable of all.

In some jobs you need a broad range of information about multiple destinations and in others you need an in-depth knowledge of one destination.

If you work for the rail network you would need to know about booking rail services and about the destination points on the network. If you worked for a tour operator you would need to know about the destinations they visited on tours, tour costs and other booking requirements.

The underpinning key to information provision is knowing where and how to find the information you need and applying that information effectively to the specific needs of your customer.

General products and services sought by customers

As seen above, whilst there are many audiences in which quotations will be prepared for, there are generic travel needs that most quotations will be based on, including:

- Transport
- Accommodation
- Transfers
- Tours
- Meals
- Travel Insurance.



Specific products and services sought by customer, based on needs

Based on identified customer needs, specific products and services may include, but not limited to:

- Adventure holidays, packages and tours
- Snow skiing holidays, packages and tours
- Specific age holidays, packages and tours
- Diving
- Cruising
- Rail
- Coach



- Sporting
- Safaris
- Family
- Overland treks/walking
- Beach
- Camping
- Campervan/car rental
- Wedding ceremonies.

Sources of travel product and services information

Whilst the sources of information that can help identify possible tourism products and services that will be helpful in preparing quotations for customers is limitless, possible sources of information are identified below.

Information sources	What sort of information can you find here?
Brochures/DVDs	Destinations and product information, packages, prices, booking conditions. Many brochures also provide information on local customs, health precautions, visa requirements, currency, shopping, hints on what to wear.
Hotel and accommodation guides and indexes	Information and contacts on accommodation.
Atlases, maps and encyclopedias	Geographical and general destinations information.
Travel guides	Destination and product information. (e.g. Lonely Planet, Fodor's, Insight, internet)
Individual timetables	Product and scheduling information, general industry information.
Automated information systems	Varied information
Computerised Reservations Systems (CRS)	Almost anything relating to airlines-flight schedules, fares, seating plans, just to name a few. In addition, most CRSs can provide you with a massive amount of other information – location times, daily exchange rates, visa information, destination information. They also provide a link into the reservations systems of many wholesalers.
International airline guides	Comprehensive worldwide air schedules, minimum connecting times, check in requirements, baggage information, airline and city codes, international time calculators, local taxes etc. The main example is the Official Airline Guide (OAG), although its use has been superseded to a great extent by the CRS.
Travel Trade Yearbook	Contacts for hundreds of companies in different sectors of the travel industry.

Information sources	What sort of information can you find here?
Travel Information Manual (TIM)/ Travel Trade Visa Guide/ Travel Express Visa Guide	Visa and other statutory requirements for overseas countries. TIM can now also be accessed on the CRS.
Passenger air tariff	Airfare information
Trade press	Industry updates, destination and product information, general news. (e.g. Travel Trade, Travel Weekly etc.)
General print and electronic media, travel magazines and even news bulletins for current issues	General destination and product information. News services can supply very current information on the day to day developments such as flood, social unrest, exchange rates and so forth.
Educationals/product familiarisations	Opportunities to experience products and services first hand.
Other organisations in the industry	To get information and advice from an organisation who specialise in a particular product or destination.
The internet, travel websites, travel advisor, blogs	A major resource of all types of information destinations, airline, current affairs, hotels, just to name a few. The internet is fast becoming an increasing popular means of booking travel arrangements.
Travel companies product launches, travel shows and information nights	A major way to gain knowledge on specific products with specific travel companies, update you on new product information on the market and to keep in touch with people in the travel industry.
Government agencies such as national parks and wildlife services or government tourism offices	General destination and product information

Additional sources of information

Whilst the above sources are most commonly used, other sources that can be accessed include, but are not limited to:

- Intranet Websites
- Internal information databases
- Product manuals
- Supplier information and sales kits and their sales representatives
- Destination and product experts in wholesale reservation call centres
- Confidential and general industry tariffs
- Preferred contracts or agreements
- Official country tourist offices, authorities and bureaus
- Your own travel experience
- Colleagues.



Types of suppliers

To date in this section, we have explored the different types of travel related products and services that may be sought for inclusion in a quotation.

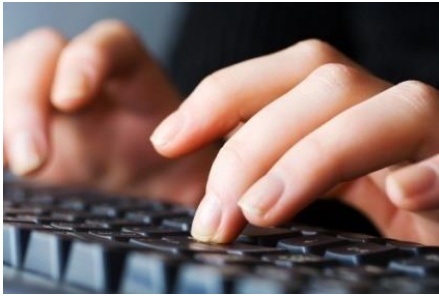
It is important to remember, that these products and services may be booked directly or supplied through a number of suppliers.

These include:

- Principals/suppliers- Provide services to the wholesalers, inbound tour operators and the travel industry
- Wholesalers/ tour operator - Packages different supplier services such as airfares, accommodation, coach tours, days tours, cruises, transfers, rail tours and rail travel, adventure tours and many other services
- Inbound tour operators - Provide travel solutions to overseas wholesalers on a specific destinations
- Airlines, coach companies and rail - Provides international, interstate and intra travel services in most destinations
- Retail agents - Provide and sell travel packages, principal and supplier services, airline, coach and rail services to the public
- Ticket consolidators
- State and regional tourism authorities
- Conference, event and incentive companies.



Consider existing agreements & preferred suppliers



Your selection of suitable suppliers will to some extent be influenced by any existing commercial agreements, commonly termed preferred agreements, that may be in place in the organisation where you are employed.

There are many suppliers out there, and sometimes it is difficult to know who to use and trust. Companies often have 'preferred' arrangements with suppliers. You will need to ask your manager for the list of 'preferred'.

A preferred agreement is a formal commercial agreement between a supplier and a travel agent which facilitates the payment of extra commission and other benefits by the supplier to the travel agent in exchange for the travel agent's agreement to sell the supplier's product.

Where there are preferred agreements in place, the expectation is that these products will be displayed and sold over other similar products. To facilitate this, specific preferred product training, information and resources are extended to the travel agent.

If a supplier is on the preferred list, it usually means they have been thoroughly checked by your company. Their finances have usually been checked and passed, and any necessary licenses obtained. It also means that your company has gathered other feedback on this supplier as to what quality of service they provide. As the agent, dealing with a supplier from a preferred list, gives you peace of mind. You can be confident that you are dealing with a competent, professional and reputable company. This confidence then extends to the client.

In addition to having their character investigated and passed, 'preferred' companies can also sometimes offer a commission override. This means a financial incentive to you to sell their product over others. These overrides are negotiated on your behalf usually by your manager, or in the case of bigger companies, by the BDMs – Business Development Managers.

'Preferred' agreements are exclusive and confidential arrangements. Both parties need to have trust in each other for it to be a successful relationship. The stronger these relationships become, the more lucrative they will be.

Dealing with a 'preferred' supplier will not guarantee success. It just reduces the risk. Preferred suppliers require constant monitoring by your company, to ensure they still fit the requirements. If you experience difficulties with a preferred, this needs to be reported to the appropriate person within your company.

Identify role of suppliers

When taking into account suppliers, it is important to understand the role they perform in providing products and services to customers. This will help determine their suitability in providing products and service.

Supplier roles include:

- Selling destinations you need
- Selling transport you require – air, car, rail, coach, cruise etc.
- Selling accommodation style you require – hotel, motel, apartment, resort etc.
- Selling the appropriate level of comfort and inclusions your client needs
- Having competitive prices and offering value for money for your client
- Having a reputation for reliability, efficiency and easy payment
- Provide quality documentation
- Employ helpful and knowledgeable staff
- Pay competitive agent commission
- Have local representation.



Activities in identifying appropriate suppliers

As seen above, many organisations will have preferred suppliers which they will use for the majority of their travel needs, however at times new suppliers will need to be selected or current suppliers reviewed.

Therefore activities associated with identifying suitable suppliers include:

- Identifying client requirements in terms of products and services
- Collecting information as to whom provides these products and services
- Identifying suitable suppliers
- Assessing alternatives against the identified requirements for the quotation
- Evaluating the alternatives against the given criteria for the quotation
- Accommodating host enterprise requirements in relation to the use of preferred suppliers, providers and carriers
- Aligning with established client preferences and individual client market research data/feedback
- Determine and select suppliers, providers and carriers to be provided as options to the client.



2.3 Calculate costs of products and services required for the quotation

Introduction

Naturally the cost provided to the travel company will differ to that to be included in a proposal as suitable mark ups will be determined in line with organisational profit expectations.

This section will explore in more detail the costing considerations that must be taken into account when determining final costs that will be presented to the customer in a quotation.

Activities associated with calculating costs of products and services

Whilst some of these activities will be explored in more detail throughout this section, the main activities associated with calculating costs of products and services should include:

- Ensuring comprehensiveness and accuracy of all information provided
- Negotiating costs with suppliers, providers and carriers to obtain optimal prices
- Calculating commissions that apply to the quotation
- Calculating mark-up net costs
- Applying host enterprise procedures to determine selling prices
- Including all relevant and legitimate taxes, fees and other charges to provide a quotation that has no hidden charges
- Incorporating currency conversions into the statement of prices, where applicable
- Factoring allowable discounts
- Considering and including package deals, where appropriate
- Taking into account seasonal and other premiums that may apply to bookings
- Estimations based on current year prices.



Negotiate costs with suppliers

In most instances travel agents are not required to negotiate costs with suppliers. Usually this is done by the wholesaler, tour operator or General Sales Agent and by specific people within the organisation, commonly termed product buyers.

There may however be occasions where in order to secure a particular product or service for your customer you may be required to go outside of the recognised channels and deal direct with the principal e.g. for a group, charter, conference, special interest or some kind of unique product/service not offered by a local supplier or if offered, where the pricing is prohibitive.

In this situation the following may be negotiable:

- The gross price
- The commission
- The Nett price
- The currency
- The method of payment
- The deposit amount and deadline
- The final payment deadline
- The cancellation and/or amendment fees
- The allocation of seats/rooms/cabins
- The release back date for unsold allocations
- The deadline for final passenger names/numbers.



Bear in mind that while you may be able to negotiate a better price you will also be required to do a substantial amount of extra work in relation to the ongoing monitoring and management of product and services sourced in this way.

In many instances, particularly with a group, there is financial risk to the travel agent and substantial deposits should be collected from the customer before entering into arrangements where you are dealing direct with the principal.

Also it is a good idea to research these suppliers to ensure that they are above board and that they genuinely offer and are able to provide the particular product and/or service contracted.

Calculate mark-up nett costs and commissions to determine a profitable selling price



A large part of the job of a travel agent is sourcing the best pricing for your client's itinerary, while at the same time ensuring that you are earning a reasonable return for effort expended and service provided.

It is essential therefore that travel consultants are familiar with the terminology and understand the various accepted pricing models used in the travel industry.

The underlying pricing principle is a business will source product and services from various principals and suppliers at a rate that is sufficiently competitive to allow for a reasonable margin.

Product and services can include airfares, which are often packaged with other products and services and offered as an inclusive tour/travel arrangement.

The costing and pricing of these products and services will take account of currency exchange rates, margins for the wholesaler and the various levels of retail travel agent commission they intend to offer.

Here is an overview of the most common methods:

Method 1 – Gross price less commission

1. Local suppliers such as hotels, guides, coach companies, transfer companies etc. sell their product to local tour operators at a rate referred to as nett nett.
2. The tour operators or wholesaler will contract for these services at the nett nett rate and add a margin to allow for a reasonable profit. This rate is termed the nett rate.
3. The tour operator or wholesaler will then add either a percentage or dollar amount to the nett rate to allow for the payment of travel agents commission.
4. This then becomes the gross price for the product and service and it is this rate which is published in brochures and on websites.
5. The product is then distributed and sold to the customer via various distribution channels, one of which is the travel agent network. In exchange for distributing (promoting and selling) their product, the tour operator or wholesaler will extend a small payment to the travel agent. This is termed travel agent commission.



The percentage commission paid will vary depending on the type of product and any preferred agreements that may be in place however it averages around 10% for land arrangements. Commission on airfares can be anything from no commission to a maximum of 9% with most being around 5%.

Method 2 – Nett plus mark-up

There are instances where a travel agent is offered or sources a nett cost for a product or service.

The travel agent is then at liberty to mark up the nett cost by adding a percentage or dollar amount to reach a gross price which is then provided to the customer.

The amount of the mark-up (percentage or dollar value) is most often influenced by the organisation and the conditions in the market place.

In this instance the difference between the nett cost and the marked up price represents the travel agent commission or margin. This typically applies to airfares where the airline or ticket consolidator will provide a nett airfare to the travel agent.

Receiving commissions

There are 3 main ways that travel agents receive their commission.

Deduction at source

The travel agent collects the gross or published price from the customer and then remits the nett amount to the supplier, tour operator or wholesaler.

For example: You have booked and collected payment for 1 nights hotel accommodation. In accordance with the published price you have collected \$200.00 (gross) from the customer. When you remit the payment to the hotel, you send them \$180.00 which represents the gross less a commission of 10% i.e. \$20.00 agent commission.

Retrospective payment

The supplier of the product or service will send the travel agent their commission after the customer has utilised the product or service.

For example: You have booked 1 night's hotel accommodation for your customer. The published price is \$200.00 for the night. You have not collected the payment as the customer has elected to pay direct using a credit card.



You have provided the credit card details to the hotel to guarantee the booking.

Once the customer has utilised the service (completed their stay at the hotel), the hotel will send the travel agent their commission of \$20.00 (10%) via one of the many payment methods available such as direct deposit, Money Direct, Smart Money, etc.

Overrides

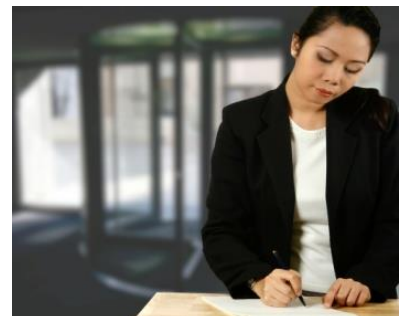
These are payments made to travel agents based on agreements in relation to volume, agreed sales targets etc.

These payments are generally over and above any commission deducted at source or received after utilisation (see above) and usually form part of a preferred agreement. Payments of overrides are usually made at agreed intervals i.e. monthly, quarterly, six monthly or annually.

Accurately calculate any additional taxes, special fees and other charges

There a number of factors that influence variations in product pricing. Here are some:

- Seasonality – high, shoulder, low or peak, off peak or combinations
- Validity dates – what prices apply to what dates
- Date of booking
- Date of travel
- Surcharges – weekend stays, extra bedding



- Restrictions – age, student, senior, nationality, validity of driver licence
- Standard – Luxury, moderate, standard, basic, budget or backpackers
- Inclusions/exclusions – meals, sightseeing, entrance fees, tour escort
- Bedding – single, twin share, triple, quad, multi/dormitory
- Child and infant costs – when is a child a child and when is an infant an infant
- Currency used and conversion rates
- Payments – early bird payments, instance purchase tickets
- Conditions of sale – book by for travel by
- Packages versus single items sold
- Stay Pay – stay 4 nights and pay for 3 nights
- Last minute deals and spot specials – used to fill remaining seats, rooms, cabins.



Accurately calculate any required currency conversions

When dealing with airlines, wholesalers and suppliers, the price that they will advise will be in local currency. There may be certain cases when you will not receive a quote in local currency, but in a commonly used currency such as USD (United States Dollars).

Some examples may be that you are quoting a price to your passenger that is:

- Sourced directly from a supplier's website that does not have the option of local currency
- Quoting an airfare from an airline's website or reservations office where the airfare is only priced in their local currency, not YOUR local currency
- Extra services provided by hotels - if unable to purchase in advance or your wholesaler does not offer that service as part of their contracted rate. e.g. meal packages, rollaway beds, wedding packages
- For some adventure or overland tours, there will be an additional amount called a 'Kitty' that cannot be prepaid in your country. It is collected by the tour leader at the start of the tour and your clients must be made aware of this amount before their arrival. The 'Kitty' amount is usually in USD to be paid in cash and is used to buy food and additional supplies while the group is on tour.



If you need to convert a foreign currency into local currency, you can use:

- The currency conversion command via your CRS systems (Galileo, Sabre or Amadeus)
- Websites such as:
 - Universal Currency Converter – <http://www.xe.com>
 - Travelex - <http://www.travelex.com.au>.

Before advising the final price in local currency to your client, ensure that you have used the correct conversion method and record both the foreign and local currency amount in the client file – just in case there is a cost discrepancy.

Securing quotes and costs from suppliers

In order to calculate the cost for the arrangements requested you will need to contact the applicable supplier, tour operator and wholesaler for the individual components that you have selected based on the customer's requirements.

Typically, contact is made via a call to the reservations area or electronically via a travel agent only area of the applicable website.

Both supplier websites and their brochures are good resources to use when researching product and services.

These 'agent only' access areas of supplier websites are user name and password protected and some will allow the agent to initiate a quote or booking.

General considerations when securing quotes and costs

It is important that when dealing with these suppliers that you bear the following in mind:

- Be polite and respectful at all times
- Have all the necessary information to hand before you make contact
- Have a pen and paper ready
- Listen and accurately record what you are told
- Get the name of the person you are dealing with
- Secure and record the quote reference number
- Request an email copy of the quote.



Securing tour operator quotes

To secure a quote from a tour operator (e.g. Peregrine, Contiki Tours Holidays etc.) you will need:

- Your agency name, password or code
- Passenger names exactly as they appear in their passports
- Tour number, name of tour, departure date and departure city
- Number of passengers travelling
- Age of passengers – especially children
- Room type and configuration - single, twin, triple
- Any additional requirements - airfares, transfers, pre and post tour hotel accommodation.



Securing wholesaler accommodation quotes

To secure a quote for an accommodation package with a wholesaler (e.g. Tempo Holidays) you need:

- Your agency name, password or code
- Passenger names exactly as they appear in their passports
- Accommodation name
- Number of night required - in and out dates
- Early and late check-in, check-out or day use
- Number of passengers travelling
- Age of passengers - especially children
- Room type and bedding configuration required - single, twin, double, triple, king, queen, adjoining rooms, kitchenette, 1 or 2 bedroom apartment
- Any additional requirements - airfares, transfers, meals, tours.



Securing wholesaler cruise quotes

To secure a quote for a cruise wholesaler e.g. (P&O, Crystal, Cunard, Carnival) you need:

- Your agency name, password or code
- Passenger names exactly as they appear in their passports
- Name of the ship or cruise company name
- Cruise name, number and date of departure and departure port
- Number of passengers travelling
- Age of passengers - especially children and seniors
- Cabin type, bedding configuration required - single, twin berth triple berth, quad berth, inside, outside, cabin, deck name or level, balcony
- Any additional requirements - airfares, transfers, pre and post cruise accommodation.



Securing car hire quotes

To secure a quote for a car hire or motorhome (e.g. Driveaway Holidays, Avis, Hertz, Budget) you need:

- Your agency name, password or code
- Passenger names exactly as they appear in their passports
- Vehicle type or code - size, air conditioned, petrol or diesel, manual or automatic
- Number of passengers travelling
- Age of passengers - especially those under 25 years and any children



- Pick-up and drop off dates - duration impacts rate
- Pick-up and drop-off times - important when calculating number of days
- Pick-up and drop-off location - fees apply for one way rentals
- Number of drivers - often surcharges apply for additional drivers
- Where the customer plans to take the vehicle - some countries are restricted
- Any additional requirements - baby seat, GPS, ski racks.

Identifying final supplier details and costs

At the conclusion of the process, you should ensure that you have secured and noted down the following information:

- The name of the supplier, wholesaler, tour operator
- The date, time and name of the person providing the quote
- The detail of the various products or service and the price – make a special note of the pricing structure i.e. per person, per rental, per room etc.
- Quote reference number.

All these details should be recorded, either written or electronically, against the customers quotation file for future reference. It is from these notes that you will compile and prepare the quotation for the customer.

In addition, it is vital that once the written email copy of the quote is received, that the content is checked against notes taken at the time of securing the quotation. This should be done before written or verbal quotations are provided to the customer. It is not unusual for there to be discrepancies which must be rectified immediately.

Mistakes are costly.



Check all calculations against all product and service components

Prior to providing the customer with a quotation you must check all your calculations in relation to the prices secured.

The process of collating and pricing the itinerary must include checking the detail of the products and services as well as how these have been priced e.g. per person, per night, or per rental etc.

Pricing for air fares is always per person and will consist of the airfare and the taxes which are subject to change up to and until the booking has been ticketed.

The common way in which other products and services are commonly priced and published have been identified below.

Product / Service	Costing method
Tours	Per person twin share
	Single supplements usually apply for single passengers
Accommodation	Per person per night twin share
	A sole guest will pay twice the twin share rate i.e. room rate
Car rentals	Per day which is equal to one 24 hour period
Motor homes	Per day or per week (1 day is equal to one 24 hour period)
Transfers	Per person per one way transfer – seat in coach/ferry/bus
	Per car or limousine per one way transfer
Cruises	Per person per cabin twin share
	Sole use of a cabin will be priced higher than the twin share price
	Port charges and taxes
Rail	Tickets – per person per one way/return journey
	Passes – per person per pass

Additional cost considerations

Apart from the detail of the actual products and services and the applicable prices, there are other considerations which you must also check and take account of:

- Mandatory organisation service, transaction or planning fee etc.
- Insurance
- Visa – are they required and how much will they cost?
- Merchant fees – most credit cards incur these fees which are between 1-4%
- Any taxes and levies which are payable direct and which are not included in the quotation
- Extra charges such as hire of GPS, baby seat, child booster, snow chains, roof rack, rollway bed, baby cot charge etc.
- Exchange rate fluctuation – if applicable.



Validity of prices must be noted. For example, a price may only be valid if the product or service is booked and deposited by a certain date, failing which the price will increase. Cruises, tours and airfares are typical examples.

You need to clearly indicate any applicable deadlines in relation to pricing and related payment e.g. deposits, part or full payment. Quotations provided to travel agents by supplier, tour operators or wholesalers will specify how long the quote is valid for, usually 7 days, after which they reserve the right to amend the prices.

Tour companies and wholesalers will sometimes guarantee prices for products only once the quote is converted to a booking and the deposit has been paid and received. Others may only guarantee prices once the booking has been paid in full and some companies will always reserve the right to amend the prices or surcharge the product in the event of drastic currency fluctuation.



Any supplier terms and conditions must be considered and noted over and above any of your own internal organisation specific, terms and conditions. For example some travel agents may not offer 7 day validity on quotations, they may only be valid for 24 or 48 hours.

Where prices have been calculated in a currency other than your local currency, it is also important to record the currency used, the exchange rate and the date the calculation was done.

You may also be required to record actual or estimated commissions. Where you have sourced product or services direct, at a nett rate, you must also record how you calculated the final gross selling price i.e. the mark-up/ margin for each product or service.

2.4 Identify terms and conditions that apply to the quotation

Introduction

All quotations will come with terms and conditions that will apply to various aspects of travel arrangements.

Terms and conditions may be provided by:

- The travel agent themselves
- Suppliers
- The individual product or service provider.

You are strongly advised to refer to these terms and conditions when providing a quotation for your customer.

It is essential that any terms and conditions are clearly identified and that customers understand them.



Types of terms and conditions

Whilst there may be an endless set of terms and conditions that may be established, to suit the needs of the respective suppliers and providers, taking into account organisational requirements and the nature of their services, there are common terms and conditions that relate to most travel related quotations.

General terms and conditions include:

- Terms and methods of payment, including dates for payment of deposits and final payment
- Notifications regarding final confirmation of the booking and, where relevant, numbers
- Cancellations and penalties and charges that apply
- Procedures and charges that apply to name and date changes for the booking
- Guarantees and warranties that apply to the products and services covered by the quotation
- Exclusion and limitation of liability clauses
- Identification of the period for which the quotation is valid
- Whether or not the quotation is subject to change with or without notice
- Reference to associated terms and conditions as imposed by third party providers
- General industry rules, regulations and codes.



Travel Agent Terms and Conditions

Each product or service included in the quotation will have a set of general conditions which will be provided to you by the wholesaler or operator that you are utilising.

They will commonly include terms and conditions relating to:

- Deposit and how to book
- Payment Options
- Amendments
- Final Payment
- Cancellations and refunds.



Following is an example of travel agent terms and conditions.

TRAVEL AGENT – TERMS AND CONDITIONS

For full terms and conditions relating to our products and services, please refer to the full terms and conditions as outlined in our brochure and on our website.

Deposit and how to book

In order to place a reservation, a non-refundable deposit of \$250.00 per person is required. Bookings made within 45 days of departure will require full payment at time of placing the reservation.

Receipt of the deposit indicates to our organisation that the traveller has agreed to their confirmed travel arrangements. Deposits paid are non-refundable.

Payment Options

- *Cheque*
- *Smart Money*
- *Money Direct*
- *Credit Cards – AMEX VISA MASTERCARD + Merchant Fee*
- *Direct deposit*

Amendments

Should the reservation be altered after the original booking has been confirmed a fee of \$150.00 per amendment will be applied to cover additional administrative and communication costs.

Depending on the nature of the change, seasonal price adjustments, additional costs or cancellation fees may also be applicable.

Final payment

Full and final payment is required no later than 45 day prior to departure.

If payment is not received by the due date, our organisation reserves the right to treat the booking as cancelled and will apply full cancellation charges as specified.

Cancellation and refunds

Cancellation fees for some programmes may vary from those stated below. Please check at the time of booking. If the reservation is cancelled the following per person fee will apply:

- Up to 45 before departure loss of deposit
- Between 45-30 days up to 50% of total cost
- Within 30 days of departure up to 100% of total cost
- After departure no refund for any unused service

All costs are subject to alteration and currency fluctuation without notice, up to and until full and final payment is received.

Supplier terms and conditions

It is important that all supplier, wholesaler, operator conditions are highlighted to the customer together with your own travel agent terms and conditions.

Here is an example of a standard travel agent attachment. These, or a similar document are routinely used as an appendix to written or email quotations or as a hand out for customers.

SUPPLIER – TERMS AND CONDITIONS

Validity

All quotes provided are valid for 7 days from date of issue and are subject to availability and change.

Car Hire

Car hire companies will require a credit card deposit and/or guarantee upon pickup of vehicle.

Hotel Check In/Out

Most hotels have a check in time of 2pm and check out time of 10am. Should you wish to arrive or depart outside of these times, a room may only be allocated to you subject to availability.

Flight Schedules

Flight schedules are subject to change. We will endeavour to notify you as soon as possible if your itinerary is affected, but please be aware that changes are out of our control.

Amendment and Cancellation Fees

Cancellation charges can be up to 100% depending on the reason for and time of cancellation. Please refer to the terms and conditions in the brochures provided.

The operator will impose cancellation and amendment fees and we strongly suggest you peruse these conditions carefully. In addition, depending on the rules and conditions of the airfare purchased, the airline will charge cancellation and amendment fees.

Insurance

Travel insurance is strongly recommended for medical, cancellation and unforeseen circumstances. Please carefully read the conditions and inclusions of your selected policy, so you know you have adequate cover.

Taxes

Most countries now require taxes to be paid in advance. Any taxes already paid are detailed in your above costing. They are however subject to change at any time prior to the air ticket being issued.

Product or service provider terms and conditions

Individual product or service providers will often have a set of terms and conditions relating to their particular product or service.

These will cover, among other items:

- Pricing policy
- Payment conditions
- Inclusions
- Exclusions
- Any restrictions or limitations.



As can be seen in this section there are many terms and conditions provided by various organisations involved in the travel booking process.

Naturally the extent and finer details of terms and conditions may seem overwhelming or not anticipated by the end user. Therefore the role of travel agents in ensuring customers understand them is a vital aspect of providing quotations.

2.5 Submit draft quotation for approval

Introduction

Now that all the vital information relating to products and services required for inclusion in a quotation have been compiled, it is now time to prepare the actual quotation itself.

There are many and varied formats used by travel agents for the provision of quotations.

Today, most are provided using some form of pro-forma document which contains standard text and where allowance is made to personalise the quotations by inserting appropriate details.

Prepare the quotation to reflect all inclusions required by the customer

General quotation inclusions

Quotations must be provided in a format that can be easily understood by a client. It is important therefore that the following general protocols are followed:

- Use official company stationery – letterhead or standard pro-forma document
- Date the quote
- Avoid the use of jargon
- Ensure correct spelling and grammar
- Include Customer/Passenger name/s
- Specify currency e.g. All prices are quoted in Singaporean Dollars
- Provide both a per person and total price
- State validity of the quote
- Detail all the arrangements included in the quote – products, services, dates, times
- Follow a logical and sequential order for arrangements
- Detail deposit amount and date required
- Cover payment options and any associated cost e.g. merchant fee
- Draw attention to the booking terms and conditions – agency and suppliers
- Outline any passport and/or visa requirements
- Recommend Travel Insurance
- Thank the customer for the opportunity to provide the quotation
- Be specific when and how you will contacting them to follow-up.



Flights

- Airline details
- Destinations and routings
- Class of travel
- Departure and return dates – remember to include the year
- Fare validity – for sale and for travel dates
- Air fare per person
- Taxes per person (always state that these are subject to change).



Accommodation

- Name of accommodation and location
- Room type and bedding configurations
- Check-in and check-out dates
- Total number of nights
- Any extras or inclusions such as meals, transfers etc.
- Cost per person per night and total amount for the stay.



Car hire/Rentals

- Name of company they are using – Avis, Budget, Hertz etc.
- Vehicle group or type – compact, midsize, group C etc.
- Transmission – manual or automatic
- Pick up and drop off dates, times and location
- Rate – if paying direct
- Rental Inclusions – mileage, additional drivers, insurances, taxes
- Any additional local payments for additional services e.g. GPS.

Cruises

- Name of the cruise line or company
- Name of the ship
- Name of cruise, including code
- Number of days or nights
- Departure date, time and location
- Return date, arrival time and location
- Cabin type and deck location.



Tours

- Tour company name
- Tour name, code and duration
- Departure date, time and location/city
- Arrival date, time and location/city
- Rooming details – single, twin, triple
- Inclusions.

Transfers

- Date, time and location of transfers
- Type of transfer – seat in coach, private transfers, limousine etc.



Insurance

- Company used
- Policy type and length of policy
- Type of cover
- Reference to PDS (Product Disclosure Statement).

Example of a standard pro-forma document for flights

<Agent Letterhead>

<insert date>

<insert name/s>

<insert address>

Dear <insert name/s>,

Further to our telephone conversation, I have pleasure in providing the following quotation for your trip to

<insert destination> in <insert date>.

Costs

Airfare: \$<insert price> per person

Taxes: \$<insert price> per person

Total: \$<insert price> per person

In order to secure these flights, the air tickets must be issued by no later than <insert date> failing which the flights will be automatically cancelled by the airline and we will have to be re-book and re-quote the airfares.

Payment

Payment must therefore be received by no later than <insert date>

Credit card payments are subject to the following surcharges:

1% for Visa and MasterCard

2.5% for Diners Club

3.5% for American Express

Direct deposits to be paid into the <insert detail> Bank as follows:

Name of Travel Agent Account: <insert detail>

Branch: <insert detail>

BSB Number: <insert detail>

Account Number: <insert detail>

Please include the quote number and the lead passenger's surname and notify us of the direct deposit by telephone call or email to:

<insert email address and telephone detail>

Flight details

Please ensure that the first name and spelling of your surname are as they appear in your passports as alterations are costly. We are holding your provisional booking under the names of:

<insert names>

Please let me know if there are any special meal requests in relation to the flight booking and any preference in terms of seating on the aircraft.

I am provisionally holding the following flights:

Wed 28 Apr Depart: Melbourne 1550 hours SQ228

Wed 28 Apr Arrive: Singapore 2140 hours Singapore Airlines

Wed 28 Jul Depart: Singapore 0955 hours SQ217

Wed 28 Jul Arrive: Melbourne 1915 hours Singapore Airlines

If you are a member of a frequent flyer club, please provide your member number so that these may be added to your booking.

Once the air tickets have been issued, cancellation and/or any changes and/or amendments to the booking will incur fees.

Travel insurance

Travel insurance is therefore strongly recommended and I am happy to provide you with further detail in relation to travel insurance. The premium payable is primarily determined by the destination, the level of cover required and your age. Once you have confirmed your booking, I will provide you with further information in relation to travel insurance.

Visa and passport requirements

Visa and Passports: <insert requirements – if applicable>

In the meantime, if you have any questions, please call me on <insert agent contact details>.

Kind regards,

<insert consultant name>

Travel Consultant

“Without a Travel Agent, You’re are on your own”



Depending on the system used, electronically generated quotations will all look different.

The basics however remain the same.

Here is an example of what such a document may look like. This quotation is for airfares, hotel accommodation and insurance.

Travel Agent Details

PROPOSAL

Quote Date: 13-12-2009
Quote No: 10275-00041760

Consultant: Super Sally PO/GroupCode:
Email: superdupertravel@bigpond.com

Charged to:
Salimeh Jones
9 Pickersgill Avenue
Cherry Orchards, Victoria 3001

Lead Passenger: JONES/SALIMEHMS
Other Passengers: BROWN/HILMEMR

Details	Qty	PP Price	Taxes	Inc. Total
Return airfares Melbourne to Hawaii Depart Melbourne 27 Dec 09 10 nights Honolulu 6 nights Maui Arrive Melbourne 13 Jan 10	2	\$1,278.00	\$554.00	\$3,664.00
MOANA SURFRIDER Ocean view room 10 nights in 27 Dec – out 06 Jan No meals	1	\$2,500.00	\$0.00	\$2,500.00
Comprehensive Insurance 12 Days Plan A	1	\$420.00	\$0.00	\$420.00
TOTAL				\$6,584.00

Conditions

Quote Condition: Please note that this is a quote only and no booking has been made. The quoted price is subject to change anytime.

Comments

This quote is valid for 7 days from date of issue

“Without a Travel Agent, You’re on your own”

Prepare secondary quotations with options

There are situations where, as part of the consultation, a number of options are requested by the client and/ or are suggested by the travel agent.

Here is an example of a quotation which offers choice based on the discussions that have taken place between the consultant and the travel agent. This quote has been provided to the customer by email.

Hi <insert name>,

Thank you for the opportunity to provide a proposal for your honeymoon. The quote is coming in at \$7,101.00 and includes:

- Economy class airfares and taxes*
- Melbourne/Kuala Lumpur/Langkawi/Kuala Lumpur/Melbourne*
- 4 nights at the Mandarin Kuala Lumpur – in 28 February – out 04 March*
- Deluxe room including breakfast*
- Arrival and departure transfers*
- 10 nights at the Andaman Langkawi – in 04 March – out 14 March*
- Deluxe room including breakfast*
- Arrival and departure transfers*

If you went for the Westin in Kuala Lumpur instead of the Mandarin, the total price would come down by around \$200.00

Notes

1) This quote is subject to change, availability and a slight variance in taxes.

2) I have based the quote on the Mandarin in Kuala Lumpur and the Andaman in Langkawi (as requested) however we could substitute for the Westin in one or both places.

The Mandarin is on request at the moment (very popular hotel) so I have taken the liberty of requesting it for the 4 nights as it can take overnight to find out if it is available or not.

The Westin (Kuala Lumpur) is currently available so should be no issue if we cannot secure the Mandarin. The Andaman in Langkawi is also currently available, as is the Westin.

3) I suggest the following flights.

28FEB MELKUL departing at 3.40pm and arriving at 8.40pm

04MAR KULLGK departing at 2.15pm and arriving at 3.10pm

14MAR LGKKUL departing at 7.39pm and arriving at 8.30pm

14MAR KULMEL departing at 9.35pm and arriving 15 Mar @ 8.15am

Once you have had an opportunity to look at the detail of the quote, I would appreciate your thoughts and feedback.

Kind regards,

<insert signature>

In the example quotation above, you will notice that the format is different and that:

- The quotation is less formal
- The 12 hour clock has been used
- Actual flight numbers have not been included
- Insurance has not been mentioned
- Terms and conditions are not covered.

All of the above is acceptable for an initial enquiry. Remember that often a customer will be securing a number of quotations from various sources. Depending on the source of the enquiry, this type of quotation is acceptable and still provides a comprehensive and professional response to a request for a quotation.

Here is an example of a quotation which includes 2 alternative destinations which is being provided formally on travel agent letterhead.

<Agent Letterhead>

<insert date>

<insert name/s>

<insert address>

Dear <insert name/s>,

Thank you for your opportunity to provide quotations for your forthcoming honeymoon. I have pleasure in providing the following options for consideration.

Option 1 – Hawaii 16 night itinerary \$14,537.00 or 20 night Itinerary \$16,537.00

Hawaii is part of the United States of America and consists of 7 islands. This itinerary is based on stays in both Oahu (Honolulu) and Maui and includes:

- *Airfares and pre-payable taxes*
- *Melbourne/Sydney/Honolulu/Maui/Honolulu/Sydney/Melbourne*
- *Accommodation*
- *10 nights Honolulu @ Moana Surfrider or Royal Hawaiian – in 27 Dec – out 06 Jan (deluxe properties on Waikiki Beach) in an ocean room*
- *6 nights Maui @ Sheraton Maui or The Westin Resort (deluxe oceanfront properties) in an ocean view room with breakfast daily*
- *Depart Maui/Honolulu 12 Jan Arrive Melbourne 13 Jan*
- *Transfers: All arrival and departure transfers to/from airports/hotels/airports*

Cost excludes: Maui hotel tax of approximately USD21.00 per room per day to be paid direct to the hotel

Deposit required: \$500.00 per person

Final payment required: 3 months prior to departure date

Visa: Required for passport holders. Issued on arrival in U.S.A and subject to securing Electronic Travel Authorization number (online) prior to departure.

Option 2 – Tahiti \$16,300.00

Tahiti is part of French Polynesia and consists of a large number of islands. This itinerary is based on stays in both Moorea and Bora Bora and includes:

- *Airfares and pre-payable taxes*
- *Melbourne/Auckland/Papeete/Bora Bora/Papeete/Auckland/Sydney/Melbourne*
- *Accommodation*
- *1 night in Papeete @ Sofitel in a mountain view room – in 26 Dec – out 27 Dec*
- *8 nights Moorea @ Sofitel Beach Resort in a luxury Garden Bungalow – in 27 Dec – out 04 Jan*
- *daily breakfast/dinner (including a compulsory New Year Eve Dinner)*
- *4 nights Bora Bora @ Marara Beach Resort in a luxury Garden Bungalow – in 04 Jan – out 10 Jan*
- *daily breakfast/dinner*
- *1 night in Papeete @ Sofitel in a mountain view room – in 11 Jan – out 12 Jan*
- *Depart Papeete 12 Jan Arrive Melbourne 13 Jan*
- *Transfers: All arrival and departure transfers to/from airports/pier/hotels/airports*

Cost excludes: Tahiti tax of approximately \$2.50 per person per night to be paid direct

Deposit required: \$500.00 per person

Final payment required: 3 months prior to departure date

Visa: Not required for passport holders for stay less than 90 days

Travel insurance is strongly recommended the cost of which is primarily determined by the destination and the level of cover required. Once you have decided on your destination I will provide you with further information in relation to travel insurance.

Please note that this is a quote only and no booking has been made. These quotes are subject to availability and change and are valid for 7 days from date of issue.

I will call you next week to discuss the outcome of your discussions with your partner. In the meantime, if you have any questions, please feel free to call me.

I look forward to speaking to you.

Kind regards,

<insert consultant name>

Travel Consultant

Again, the quote has been provided in a different format, still acceptable and professional.

Submit draft quotation

Once the draft quotation has been prepared along with any secondary quotations, providing viable options to the customer, it is now time to submit the quotation for approval or amendment before the final quotation can be prepared and sent to customers.

Activities associated with submitting draft quotation may include:

- Provision of draft quotation to supervisor, manager or designated internal departments
- Verifying inclusions, exclusions and calculations included in the quotation
- Checking accuracy and comprehensiveness of the quotation
- Ensuring the quotation conforms with internal formatting and presentation requirements
- Checking the legitimacy of the quotation.

Depending on the review of the draft proposal the following actions may take place:

- Amend the quotation – where changes are required
- Record and file the approved quotation.



2.6 Amend draft quotation, as required

Introduction

There are many reasons quotations can be done several times before a final package is decided upon. Most of the reasons are out of the control of the person who constructed the original draft version of the quotation.

Regardless of the need to make changes, any changes must be:

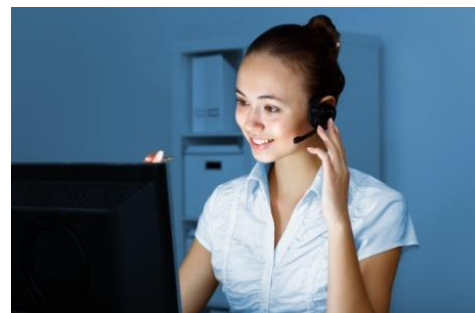
- Reflect need for change
- Done in a timely manner
- Accurate and relevant to the changes.

For these reasons all quotations are kept on record in the clients file, either manually or electronically. This makes the information easily accessible to the entire team in the office ensuring efficiency in situations where the quotation needs to be amended.

Reasons for amendments

There are endless reasons for the need to change a draft quotation including but not limited to:

- Changes requested by customers – these can relate to changes or new requests in travel requirements or arrangements
- Changes requested by management – these can relate to errors identified, format, policies and procedures or recommendations
- Changes notified by suppliers or product/service providers – these can relate to availability, price changes, conditions etc.
- Changes notified by governments – including taxes, visas, travel advisories or warnings.



Adjust and update quotations to take account of changed requests or arrangements

Client changes

If the client has requested changes, then you need to also check all elements of the original quote to see if and how they are affected and forward the updated quotation to the customer.

Some travel agents will impose charges where the change requested by the customer entails extensive itinerary planning and quoting. In most instances where a fee is applied, this is deducted from the total value of the booking once the customer confirms the booking by paying the required deposit. You will need to comply with the business requirements in this regard.



Changes notified by management

Normally when reviewed by a colleague or manager changes may need to take place due to:

- Errors may have been identified
- Suggestions made to ensure the quotation is in the most 'user friendly' format for customers
- Policies or procedures may impact on the quotation.

Changes notified by suppliers

There are situations where the supplier, tour operator or wholesaler will advise you of changes, in which case these changes or amendments must be provided to your customer.

Here are some reasons that suppliers can/will make changes:

- Change in costing due to currency fluctuations (usually increase)
- Change in departure or arrival times of flights, tours, rail, coach etc.
- New taxes and charges for flights or car hire
- Tour may be cancelled and customer rescheduled onto another option
- Departure or return date or location
- Number of passengers in the group
- Hotel changes such as alternative hotel or change of room type
- Flights may be rescheduled or rerouted causing changes in taxes
- A product or service may be cancelled due to operational reasons
- Weather conditions e.g. lack of snow, hurricanes, and floods etc.
- An 'Act of God' such as a natural disaster or war
- Expiration or withdrawal of the deal, package, offer etc.



If the supplier has made changes then they will provide you with an updated quote / invoice with the changes and new costing. It is important that you carefully check the new amended details and if they affect the original quotation provided, that you forward an updated quotation in writing to the customer.

Process of amending draft quotation

Once the desired changes have been identified amending the draft quotation may include:

- Revising draft quotation on the basis of feedback received and/or errors and omissions identified
- Representing revised draft quotation for approval
- Preparing secondary quotations, as appropriate, to supplement primary quotation as deemed appropriate by the nature and extent of client requirements.



2.7 Record and file the approved quotation

Introduction

The differences between various quotes may be subtle such as moving the departure day by just one or a few days. This however may have a less than subtle impact on the quotation where the change of date may mean a change of seasonality, from low to high, and thus a much higher price.

Customers often do not understand why their quotation has increased simply because they are departing a few days earlier or later. It is therefore important to be able to refer to the previous quotations where the old date of departure had been recorded.

Record all details of adjusted quotations and keep on file

Remember to keep copies of every version of quotations on file to avoid any discrepancies or disputes at a later date.

Individual businesses will have their own systems, processes and procedures which have been tailored to suit their particular requirements. You are of course expected to comply with these at all times. In general, most agencies will use software that allows for version control in relation to quotations.

Where this is not an option, you will have to devise and implement your own system.



Bear in mind that there are 2 parts to the quotation process:

- Recording, filing and retaining quotations provided to you by product and service suppliers e.g. Wholesalers, Tour Operators etc. This includes any and all supplier initiated changes sent to you e.g. tour price increase
- Recording, filing and retaining quotations provided by you (or your colleagues) to the customer. This includes any and all supplier initiated changes sent to you where you have communicated these to the customer and any and all customer initiated changes.

Methods to record and file quotations

In both instances records must be kept in one of the following ways:

- Hard copies – physical printouts filed in date order
- Electronic copies – soft copies filed in version order
- Emailed copies – retained in client email folder.



Regardless of the method of recording and filing quotations that is used by an organisation it is essential that:

- All relevant persons have access to files including the most current version
- Everyone understands and follows the correct procedures
- Updates of files are recorded and easily identified
- The most current version is easily identifiable.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

These Work Project Activities are based on the Case Study as previously identified.

2.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Prepare a suitable template or file in which to record information.

2.2. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Identify products and services sought by customers
- Identify sources of travel product and services information that you have used to collect information
- Identify types of suppliers and providers that you would use
- Collect information to add to quotation.

2.3. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Calculate costs for products and services as required for the quotation.

2.4. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Identify any terms and conditions.

2.5 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Prepare a draft quotation for the customer.
-

Summary

Prepare the quotation

Establish files to record the quotation

- Process of collecting customer information and travel needs
- Methods to prepare quotations
- Importance of recording accurate information
- Benefits of accurately recording information
- Use of industry codes
- Using a Quotation Planner
- Quotation formats
- Inclusions in formal quotations.

Identify appropriate supplier and provider alternatives

- Importance of collecting information on different suppliers, products and services
- General products and services sought by customers
- Specific products and services sought by customer, based on needs
- Sources of travel product and services information
- Types of suppliers
- Consider existing agreements & preferred suppliers
- Identify role of suppliers
- Activities in identifying appropriate suppliers.

Calculate costs of products and services required for the quotation

- Activities associated with calculating costs of products and services
- Negotiate costs with suppliers
- Calculate mark-up nett costs and commissions to determine a profitable selling price
- Receiving commissions
- Accurately calculate any additional taxes, special fees and other charges
- Accurately calculate any required currency conversions
- Securing quotes and costs from suppliers
- Check all calculations against all product and service components.

Identify terms and conditions that apply to the quotation

- Types of terms and conditions
- Travel Agent Terms and Conditions
- Supplier terms and conditions
- Product or service provider terms and conditions.

Submit draft quotation for approval

- Prepare the quotation to reflect all inclusions required by the customer
- Prepare secondary quotations with options
- Submit draft quotation.

Amend draft quotation, as required

- Reasons for amendments
- Adjust and update quotations to take account of changed requests or arrangements
- Process of amending draft quotation.

Record and file the approved quotation

- Record all details of adjusted quotations and keep on file
- Methods to record and file quotations.

Element 3:

Submit the quotation

3.1 Identify the required submission method

Introduction

Once the final quotation has been confirmed and filed it is now time to present it to the customer.

One of the first steps in this process is to identify the best method in which to get the proposal to the customer.

Given that a travel company now can reach customers in all corners of the globe, through electronic communication and social media, in many cases the traditional method of face to face meetings may not be possible.

Whilst face to face contact is still the most preferred method, there are many submission methods that can be used to suit the needs of both the customer and travel agent.

Submission methods

Quotations are provided to customers in one of the following ways:

- Telephone
- Facsimile
- E-mail
- Mail
- Skype or other video conferencing system
- Internal communication to other personnel or departments
- In-person presentation to client or group of clients.



Submission considerations

There are a number of considerations that must be taken into account when selecting the most appropriate submission method.

Some considerations include:

- Location of the customer – naturally if the customer is not located in your area, the concept of face to face discussion is not possible
- Number of persons to receive quotation – when preparing quotations for business purposes or for a number of travellers, the quotation may need to be sent to many persons in different locations
- Reliability of submission methods – depending on the region, some submission methods, such as mail, may be unreliable and quite simply take too long to get to the customer

- Types of documentation required – if the quotation also contains reference materials such as brochures from product and service providers, mailing of documents may be the most preferred method
- Time frames required – in the event of immediate travel, electronic communication will be the most desirable submission method as it is instantaneous
- Costs – naturally there is great cost associated in mailing proposals on a regular basis. Depending on the organisational requirements, initial quotations may be sent electronically, as it is the most cost effective method of submission.



Submission requirements

As previously mentioned, each organisation will have quotation requirements that must be followed, normally relating to presentation

To avoid misunderstanding, it is recommended that all quotations are provided in writing and should:

- Be on company stationery
- Follow a logical and sequential order of arrangements
- Contain no jargon
- Use good grammar and correct spelling
- Be accurate
- State validity
- Detail terms and conditions
- Outline the steps required to convert quotation to a booking e.g. deposit
- Offer payment options.



Follow up on submission

Once a proposal has been sent it is important that the travel agent makes contact with the customer.

If a customer comes into your agency for a quotation but does not make a booking, it is important to follow up with a telephone call. Call them within your company's specified time frame which is generally 2-3 days after the quote was provided. If you can't reach them by phone and you have their email address, send them the quote and ask them if they are ready to commit.

The purpose of this contact is to:

- Show that you are professional and care about the customer
- Ensure they have received the quotation
- Clarify any initial points they may have



- To see if they have any further questions at this stage
- Advise them of future steps or actions
- To see if they want to go ahead with the booking.

Depending on when they are travelling and also what product they are purchasing, it may be appropriate to re-check the pricing and availability before making contact

3.2 Provide the quotation

Introduction

Requests for quotations will be received in a number of ways, typically face to face, by telephone or via an email. The different submission methods were explained in the previous section.

Depending on organisation benchmarks and workload, travel agents will provide quotes:

- On the spot
- Within a stated and agreed time frame.

It is vital that you honour your commitment in relation to due dates or deadlines given to the customer for the provision of the quotation. In the unlikely event that you are unable to meet the target timeframe, that you make contact with the customer and agree a new revised date or time.

It is very probable that you are not the only travel agent that the customer has contacted. While many passengers will book based on price, there are equally as many who value good service more.



Neglecting to keep your customer informed may mean that by the time you provide the quote, they have booked elsewhere and you have wasted your time.

This section will explore in more detail the steps and considerations associated with face to face meetings in which travel agents meet with customers to:

- Discuss quotations
- Confirm and book travel arrangements.

Customer service basics when presenting quotations

It is a fundamental requirement that staff attempt to create sales out of quotations as opposed to simply preparing quotations.

When presenting quotations customer service essentials include the need to:

- Have comprehensive product knowledge
- Remember to consider customer needs, wants and preferences and suggest only those products and services that meet these identified criteria



- Ask questions – to gather information from the customer to identify if the quotation meets their needs, wants and preferences and to clarify related issues
- Be proactive – that is, you need to be able to initiate interaction with customers rather than wait for them to come to you and ask a question or make a purchase
- Provide information, recommendations, advice and suggestions that aligns with identified customer need
- Sell the benefits of products and services – as opposed to simply stating the features of the products and services
- Overcome objections by customers to making a purchase – by identifying the root cause for the objection and then applying acceptable problem-solving techniques
- Allow customers time and opportunity to consider their purchase – as opposed to rushing them, pressuring them or intimidating them into buying
- Make legitimate all add-on/complementary sales – to optimise the value of the sale and providing what the customer wants without pressuring the customer
- Close the sale – as opposed to allowing the customer to continually ‘think about it’ and eventually decide not to purchase.



These customer service skills will be explained in more detail through this manual. That said, it is important to remind yourself of them as the role of providing quotations in person is just more than passing over a piece of paper.

Prepare for the quotation presentation

Before providing any quotation it is essential that you are prepared and ready to go when the customer arrives.

It is very unprofessional for customers to arrive to discuss a quotation only to find you still organising things – get it ready well in advance.

Things to ensure are:

- Sufficient copies of quotations have been prepared
- Pens and paper are available
- Any refreshments have been arranged
- Phone calls have been diverted
- The designated area for the discussion is arranged – whether at your desk, a separate table or meeting room
- Excess noise from outside has been minimised to the best extent possible
- Others have been advised not to contact you during your meeting
- Your mobile is turned off
- Seating is sufficient for the numbers expected
- All the required support materials are present – see below.



Ensure supportive materials are present

In many cases, supportive materials may be required to compliment or explain inclusions in a proposal.

The purpose of providing a proposal is to give customers detailed information relating to their travel needs. In many cases, the travel agent will not explain every fine detail, but present an overview and then give materials for customers to take away, to read in their own time.

That said, any relevant support materials should be close at hand including:

- Websites (via internet and intranet)
- Product manuals
- Supplier information and sales kits
- Industry tariffs
- Brochures and flyers (hard and electronic)
- Fare sheets
- Timetables.



3.3 Explain and expand on the quotation

Introduction

Whilst you as the travel agent may have spent considerable time researching and developing a quotation for a customer, it is important to remember that the customer may have only seen an initial quotation.

Also it is important to remember that customers do not have the same degree and depth of knowledge in the travel industry and the processes involved in making bookings, and that they will need explanation from yourself to help their understanding.

As mentioned, some of the key aspects of providing a quotation is to:

- Explain in more detail the key pieces of information in them
- Answer any questions customers may have
- Provide suggestions and recommendations
- Outline the processes associated with confirming and organising travel arrangements
- Guide them through the sales process.



Without having a sound understanding of what information is included in a quotation, no further action is likely to happen.

Therefore an important part of the quotation process is to provide clear information to customers.

Considerations when providing quotation information

When you provide information to customers it is absolutely essential that it is:

- Up-to-date
- Accurate
- Comprehensive – make sure you tell the customer about any ‘less than attractive elements’ of what you recommend
- Honest
- Straight-forward and easily interpreted and understood
- Concise – you certainly don’t want to give customers the impression you are rushing them but you also need to be sensitive to:
 - Their need to ‘get going’
 - Your need to get on with other work and serve other customers.



Interpersonal skills when providing quotation information

When providing quotation information you need apply several appropriate interpersonal skills such as being:

- Engaged with the process of providing information – you have to show you are interested in the person you are talking to and interested in what they might be going to do. Never indicate boredom or disinterest
- Courteous and polite – using the customer’s name where it is known or following house policy regarding the use of ‘Sir’, ‘Madam’ etc., not interrupting them when they are talking, not rushing them
- Sensitive and understanding – taking into account the fact that the customers probably do not appreciate any local customs, words, terms etc. that apply
- Committed to the exchange – you have to genuinely want to help them. This can include sharing their excitement, understanding their confusion about quotation details and making sure that all the questions they need answered are answered, even the unasked ones. It is important to read their non-verbal communication to try to determine whether or not they have a need for information that has not been supplied and has not been requested
- Culturally sensitive and appropriate.



Process of explaining and expanding on the quotation

The process of explaining and expanding on the quotation has some vital elements that must be covered, including:

- Providing personal interpretation and explanation of the quotation
- Providing supplementary information as required
- Explaining the reasons for charges and fees included in the quotation
- Assisting the client to understand the reputation and expertise of nominated suppliers, providers and carriers
- Providing supporting brochures and marketing materials to assist with understanding of the quotation.



3.4 Encourage questions from the client

Introduction

Given that a quotation presentation will have one or more distinct objectives, it makes sense that you incorporate into the actual delivery of the presentation opportunities for customers to seek clarification on issues that are important to them.

This section looks at the role of handling and using questions to ensure customers understand the key elements of the quotation and that their needs are being met in the quotation.

Role of questions

It is important to remember that questions are a normal part of most quotation presentations. They should be encouraged and used by both the travel agent and the customer as it aims to clarify and resolve any outstanding points of a quotation.

Travel agents should see questions from customers as a positive thing and not as an interruption or a distraction.

Questions:

- Demonstrate the customer is interested, paying attention and that the quotation reflects their stated needs
- Provide an extra opportunity for the objectives to be achieved by:
 - Clarifying issues
 - Giving examples
 - Restating facts
- Enable a check to be made on the level of understanding the customer has in relation to quotation details
- Facilitate interaction with the customer.



Listening to customer questions

Listening is sometimes referred to as the neglected skill.

Because we listen so often, we assume we are good at it and don't need to spend any time worrying about how to do it, or how to improve doing it. Nothing could be further from the truth in most cases!

Effective listening:

- Encourages customers to fully transmit their message by indicating our interest and concern for what they have to say
- Increases the likelihood that the receiver (you) is in possession of all the relevant facts before proceeding with their answer
- Improves the quality of relationships – better communication is built in better listening and better relationships are built on better communication
- Assists in problem resolution – no problem can be effectively resolved until both parties are in full possession of all the facts
- Enhances the chance of a proper understanding between the travel agent and the customer – due to the transmission of information relevant to the quotation as a whole or a specific issue in the quotation
- Reduces many problems and conflicts related to a specific issue in the quotation.

Types of listening

We have two listening options.

- Active listening - involves listening only
- Reflective listening - involves giving verbal feedback that ensures the channel of communication continues, clear and without conflict.

Active listening

When engaged in active listening, you do not speak, except for brief words designed to encourage the customer to keep talking, you only listen.

You allow your body language to encourage the customer.

Active listening is:

- Showing sensitivity to the customer and indicating all due respect
- Displaying empathy with the customer – this can mean aligning with their emotions (frustration, anger, joy, confusion, satisfaction) as well as with the content of the verbal message they are sending
- Demonstrating your attention in all your non-verbal signals – by looking at them, nodding, showing displays of interest
- Not interrupting
- Encouraging the other person to continue by encouraging behaviour – this includes nods, murmurs, short words of encouragement



- Concentrating on what is being said and not thinking of something else – which means forcing yourself to focus on the speaker and their message rather than allowing your mind to lose focus and drift off somewhere else
- Not being judgemental – meaning you focus on the question and refrain from inferring characteristics about the speaker from what they have said.

Reflective listening

In this variation, you still listen to the customer, but you encourage them to continue with your words rather than non-verbally.

Reflective listening is especially useful where emotions are seen to be clouding the issue due to lack of understanding, frustration, and confusion.

This form of listening enables you to acknowledge the way the customer is feeling.

Reflective listening requires you to:

- Paraphrase what the customer says – that is, sum up what has been said and repeat it back to them in your own words
- Read between the lines of what is actually being said – by factoring in the message that their emotion is sending as well as the words they are using
- Utilise questioning to sum up or clarify the situation – allowing you to use questions as part of the communication exchange.

When using reflective listening there is still a need for you to continue being non-judgemental, refrain from making comments or interrupting, and to continue being sensitive.



Methods to aid effective listening

Effective listening requires practice, and concentration is the key.

Practice should be focussed and based on the following points:

- Prepare yourself to listen
- Become interested
- Face the customer when they are asking the question
- Keep an open mind
- Don't be dismissive of questions
- Identify the main idea
- Listen critically
- Don't get distracted
- Take notes
- Help where necessary
- Reflect on what has been said
- Keep quiet.



Ask questions to the customer

As the travel agent, there is nothing wrong with asking questions yourself to the customer.

The asking of questions is a powerful tool in communication and ensuring the customer understands what you are presenting as part of your quotation.

In addition, there may be further information that customers need to provide to help facilitate the travel booking or to help construct further additions to a quotation.

Questioning is not simply a method of eliciting information, although it naturally performs that primary role, but you can ask questions to check the level of understanding of the material or quotation you have presented, and you can use questions as a means of introducing some 'action' into what is generally a fairly passive activity.

Reflective questioning

'Reflective questioning' is the same idea as reflective listening, in that it involves repeating back to the speaker what they have just said. In addition, as its name states, reflective questioning puts the words in the shape of a question.

This method shows the customer that:

- You have listened to what they've said
- Gives them feedback as to whether or not you have focussed on the main points of the proposal
- Encourages them to go on and provide more information
- Encourages them to clarify what they've already stated.



Providing accurate and comprehensive responses

Once customers have asked their necessary questions, it is vital that you are able to provide accurate and comprehensive responses, that are tailored to the questions and any unspoken concerns the customer may have.

It is vital that all answers to questions are truthful. There is no room for you to make up answers on-the-spot just because you don't want to appear stupid or lacking in knowledge.

Despite all the effort and preparations you make there will always be times when you don't know the answer to a question, so you have to be prepared to admit this when the situation arises.

The basic approach to responding when asked a question you don't know the answer to is to 'take the question on notice' – simply get the details of the question and promise to research it and then get back to the individual with the answer.

Never let your inability to answer a question shake your confidence or throw you off course when providing a quotation. No-one can ever know all the answers to all the questions that could be posed.

The key to responding to these questions is not so much the information you don't know, but how you go about handling the situation, researching the question, finding the answer and then passing the relevant information on.

3.5 Advise client of action to make booking

Introduction

Naturally the overriding purpose of providing a quotation to a customer, is for them to agree with what information has been presented to them and to help facilitate the booking of travel services.

When closing in on the sale it is important to monitor customer buying signals and correctly identify and respond to them.

Failure to act promptly on the appropriate signals can result in a lost opportunity, one never again to be recaptured.

If a person decides to buy 'now' and that moment is not taken, the same person can reverse that decision about the same product – even at a lower price – a moment, hour or day later.

This underlines that a decision to buy is not a decision that lasts forever – it is a transient moment that we must seize with both hands.

Everyone has experiences where they were primed to make a purchase but didn't due to a lack of service staff, lack of someone to process the transaction, or the simple lack of a question such as 'Are you ready to book'?

Often, that buying decision is never repeated and the sale simply evaporates – the customer spends their money elsewhere, or they change their mind and decide not to make that purchase.

Identify buying signals

At some point in the consultation with your customer, they will give you an indication that they are ready to buy. Some buying signals are obvious and yet others are indirect and not so apparent. Customers will generally signal interest through their questions and their actions. In any instant it is time to stop selling and close the sale!

Questions to indicate a readiness to buy:

- How early do we need to book?
- Do you accept credit cards?
- Are there seats available on 8 January?
- Do I need to pay a deposit?
- Can you arrange for vegetarian meals?



Actions that show a commitment

There are a number of signs that indicate customers will make a commitment to a sale.

These include:

- Taking out their cheque book or wallet
- Looking for a pen to fill out a booking form
- Spending a long time studying one particular product
- Positive body language, leaning forward in their chair, responding to your eye contact, alert and attentive, frequently nodding.

You've received some obvious buying signals and you're confident that your customer is ready to make a decision to buy. Many sales are lost because the consultant is not confident to ask for the sale. How? Try:

- "How will you be paying for this?"
- "Would you like me to go ahead and make the booking now?"
- "Can you leave a deposit with me?"
- "So, what do you think?"
- "Is this what you're after?"

After making the necessary arrangements, summarise the current situation, tell them what will happen next and how long it will take, ask if they have any further questions or anything else you can do for them.

Actions to make booking

Naturally the actions associated with making bookings relating to each travel enquiry will differ depending on the arrangements and components involved, there are a number of common actions that need to take place.

Possible actions to make booking may include:

- Including organisational contact details in the quotation
- Advising client of web-based opportunities to lodge a booking
- Notifying client of any early-bird discounts or bonuses that apply to placement of bookings before a nominated date
- Confirming need for deposit to accompany booking, where applicable.



Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

These Work Project Activities are based on the Case Study as previously identified.

For the following Work Project Activities (3.1-3.5), the trainer will play the role of the customer. You will be required to submit the quotation to the Trainer.

3.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Identify the preferred submission method in which to send the quotation to the customer.

3.2. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Send the submission using the preferred method
- Follow up with the customer after the submission has been sent.

3.3. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Arrange and hold a meeting with the customer to present and explain the quotation.

3.4. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Encourage questions from the customer to ensure understanding and agreement
- Ask questions to the customer to clarify quotation items.

3.5 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Advise the customer how they can proceed with the booking.

Summary

Submit the quotation

Identify the required submission method

- Submission methods
- Submission considerations
- Submission requirements
- Follow up on submission.

Provide the quotation

- Customer service basics when presenting quotations
- Prepare for the quotation presentation
- Ensure supportive materials are present.

Explain and expand on the quotation

- Considerations when providing quotation information
- Interpersonal skills when providing quotation information
- Process of explaining and expanding on the quotation.

Encourage questions from the client

- Role of questions
- Listening to customer questions
- Types of listening
- Methods to aid effective listening
- Ask questions to the customer
- Providing accurate and comprehensive responses.

Advise client of action to make booking

- Identify buying signals
- Actions that show a commitment
- Actions to make booking.

Element 4: Follow-up the quotation

4.1 Advise client of any changes that will affect the provided quotation

Introduction

As mentioned in Section 2.6 of this manual, changes to quotations are a common occurrence. Whilst the changes may come from a variety of sources including products and service providers, suppliers, the travel agent or customers themselves, a key requirement is that customers are:

- Aware of changes as they happen
- Understand the changes
- Understand the consequence of changes
- Understand any future action to be taken.



Contact and advise clients of changes

It is essential that customers are contacted in a timely manner as soon as changes become evident that are not initiated by customers.

Normally the best way is through telephonic or electronic means depending on the complexity of the change and the preferred method of communication of the customer.

You will need to fully explain any changes to a quotation or proposed itinerary, as caused by, but not limited to:

- Natural causes
- Political unrest
- Closure of third party providers
- Restrictions on travel.

In reality there are endless reasons why changes take place.



Providing a revised quotation incorporating identified changes

There are many variables that can alter the cost that you have provided. Generally a quotation can only be honoured for 7 days unless otherwise specified by the agent.

If your customer decides to convert the quotation into a booking, it is recommended that you do 2 things:

- Check availability
- Update your quotation.

When a customer decides to book the arrangements previously quoted, they may make or ask for some changes. These may appear insignificant however they may impact the final price.

Here are some examples of changes that may change the original quotation:

- Change of departure date – seasonality
- Change of date for a product or service e.g. tour or cruise
- The number of passengers – may impact rooming
- Age of passengers vary to those originally provided – infants/children
- Addition or reduction of product or services
- Late booking fees
- Land only surcharge if air not booked
- Expiry of the quotation – no longer valid.



Suppliers may also make changes to their product, service or price. Wholesalers often need to put together their brochure/website prices 6-12 months ahead of release. During the selling season they may need to increase the prices for a range of reasons, most commonly currency rate changes and air fare increases.

Currency fluctuations may sometimes result in a lower fare in which case the price may come down although this is rare.

Under normal circumstances, most suppliers will provide the agent and therefore the customer, with advance notice (in writing) of any impending price changes and provide a time limit by which time full payment must be paid in order to protect against the new increased prices. As a rule this applies to deposited booking only and not quotations.

Air fares that are stand alone or part of a package will have a ticket-time limit date to issue the air ticket failing which the fare quote will expire and will have to be requoted.

Any changes to the original quotation provided, whether voluntary or involuntary, should always be provided to the customer both verbally and in writing. You will leave yourself and your employer open to disputes and claims etc. if you do not do this.

Highlight any new, changed or special conditions or limitations

Be careful to include and highlight any new, changed or special conditions or limitations.

Here are some examples:

- Earlybird – book and pay by dates and deadlines
- Discounts available for full or part advance payment
- Guaranteed tour departure dates – yes or no and implications if not
- Free inclusions when booking a particular airline in conjunction with a tour – pre and post tour accommodation or transfers
- Qualifications for extra tour discounts – e.g. 2nd tour or past passenger discount.

Many coach tour operators offer a product which, when purchased at the time of booking, affords some protection in relation to monies paid for the tour where the passenger either needs to change a tour date or cancel inside the specified cancellation period.

Two examples are:

- Globus – SafetyNet Protection Policy
- Trafalgars – Gold Seal Additional Protection.

These products and others are not a substitute for travel insurance which must also be offered to the customer either as part of the quotation (recommended) or at the time of booking and payment of any money.

Be diligent in presenting and drawing customer's attention to all the applicable terms and conditions for various products and services being quoted or booked.

There are various ways that this can be achieved, here are some:

- Provide the relevant product or service brochures
- Refer the customer to the relevant website – if applicable
- Email a soft copy
- Hand the customer a hard copy
- Summarise the critical terms and conditions in the quotation.



You will need to comply with the business requirements in this regard.

Filing updated quotations

Once updated quotations have been completed and forwarded to customers and relevant stakeholders they must be filed in accordance with organisational policies and procedures.

The activities associated with filing updated quotations, including the filing the paper-based revised quotation and updating required electronic files, has been previously identified in Section 2.7 of this manual.

4.2 Provide additional advice and assistance, as requested

Introduction

Once all changes have been made, it is time for the customer to decide if the quotation meets their needs and if they would like to book the travel or not.

By this time, the travel agent would have explained the details of the quotation and answered any questions in which the customer may have.

The two key pieces of follow up customer service that can be provided before the customer decides to book or not is to:

- Provide additional advice and assistance – different activities will be discussed in this section
- Maintain regular contact with customers – this will be discussed in the next section.

The key thing to remember in both situations is not to uncomfortably rush the customer but try to provide as much information and advice to help them make an educated and informed decision.



Highlight, explain and promote features and benefits

Besides providing information in a quotation, travel agents should try as much as possible to promote the features and benefits of the products.

In a travel environment, customers want to understand what or how they can benefit from products and services.

Naturally customers are only interested in satisfying their needs and wants. In the selling process this is where you need to bring out the WIIFM (or the 'what's in it for me?')

'The tour price includes two meals per day and uses air-conditioned coaches'.

By itself, it's a pretty bland statement which highlights only the features. Features alone do not relate to a customer's needs or wants. There is no WIIFM, that is, no benefit for the customer.

A feature involves factual information and can be a product, a service or an inclusion. It will rarely sell anything. What you need to consider is how the feature will benefit the customer, how that feature is going to meet your customer's needs and expectations and how you are keeping their interests in mind. After stating the feature, ask yourself 'so what?'

'The tour price includes two meals per day. That is excellent value and means you do not have to budget for food. You don't need to spend your leisure time wondering where to eat or worrying about the quality or standard of food'.

'You are going to find it very hot in Italy in July. It's important that you have an air-conditioned coach so that you keep cool, refreshed and comfortable throughout the tour.'



A benefit is that the feature will actually do for the client. When you sell to your customers in terms of benefits, it displays an awareness of their needs and wants and consideration of their comfort and enjoyment.

People buy products and services on the basis of what they will do for them. When you sell to your customers in terms of the benefits to them, they feel reassured that you have their individual interests at heart.

Brochures are a really effective sales tool to highlight features and benefits. The consultant should personalise the brochure by underlining, highlighting and circling items that are significant to the client. It will assist with product comparisons; make it easier to remember what was discussed and will maintain their original enthusiasm. Pictures and maps contained in the brochure will help display the quality and type of services provided and the attractions of the destinations visited.

Promote additional products and options to enhance an itinerary

Sometimes customers are not aware of all the product types available for purchase within their holiday. Most customers will come to you to book air, hotels and maybe transfers.

There are many other products that you can offer in addition to the basic components. They are as follows:

- Coach tours
- Rail journeys
- Cruises and yachting
- Car hire
- Independent tours
- Adventure holidays
- Entrance tickets to theme parks, museums and exhibitions.



Identify opportunities to enhance quality of service

A customer will always appreciate a consultant who goes the extra mile. In order to achieve this, you need to listen to your clients needs, record them on paper and always ensure that you refer the product back to their needs. The clients need confirmation that what you are quoting on is what they actually want.

For example, if your client requested a resort with spa treatments and beauty therapy facilities, provide details on these services available at the resort you are recommending. If there was an independent operator external to the hotel which offered fabulous treatments, let the clients know and offer them a list of services so that they can compare them to the hotel offers for both the product and price. This information is readily available either from the internet or from the Wholesaler you deal with.

If a client tells you which Resort they would like to stay at, try and offer this Resort from a Wholesaler who has a special or bonus available. The client will love you for it. When a client wishes to travel to a particular destination, offer a list of suggestions for them to do at their leisure providing detail such as description of the tour, price and a timetable of when it operates.

If a client is open to any Airline carrier, offer one which has a special or has newer and more up to date facilities on board.

4.3 Maintain contact with the client

Introduction

Like in any organisation, customers want to feel valued and reminded that they are important to a business.

One way to do this is to make contact with customers on a regular basis. Again, this is not to add additional pressure on customers but to let them know you are at their service and happy to help, provide additional advise or to action the next step in the booking process when and where required.

Making regular contact shows your customers that you are genuinely interested in helping them with their travel plans and even if they don't go ahead with their travel plans this time, they are much more likely to contact you in the future.

Considerations when maintaining contact with customers

Maintain contact with the client may include, but not limited to:

- Adhering to enterprise schedule of contacts with clients
- Being sensitive to client resentment to contact
- Determining client preferences for contact
- Apologising for contact that is inconvenient
- Accommodating client requests to cease contact.

It is important to note, that there is a fine balance between the 'right' amount of contact and being overbearing. Quite often it is important to think of yourself 'in the shoes of the customer' in determining what is the right amount of contact.



Recording client contact conversations

It is also good practise to record any and all conversations with both suppliers and customers. This is most commonly done via a notepad facility in the applicable software being used. In the absence of an electronic notepad facility, you should create and use a running sheet which allows you to record:

- The date of the conversation
- The names of the people concerned – who spoke with whom
- The content of the conversation.

This is essential, as not only do travel agents have only one customer, but they may have many contacts with one customer. It is hard to remember every conversation or communication you may have with each and every customer. By keeping detailed records can they see what has been discussed.

In addition, if an additional travel agent is called upon to help facilitate a booking, they have all the necessary information at hand.



4.4 Implement actions to close the sale

Introduction

Part of the selling job is to encourage customers to make a buying decision.

This is one of those aspects that is sometimes contentious and nearly always fraught with danger.

The last thing you want to do is give the impression that you are trying to force or coerce the customer into buying, or trying to move them on or hurry them up.

As they say in other areas, it's not so much what you say in this instance, it's the way you say it – including your body language.

That said, the key objective of any business is to make sales. Why prepare quotations if no-one makes a booking as a result.

Ways to encourage a purchase

Methods to encourage customers to make a purchase can include:

- Regular contact (but not at annoying levels) with the customer to offer service
 - Offering positive and informed comments about the travel plans and suggested itinerary the customer is considering, inspecting, or looking at
 - Mentioning, within the correct context, that the current price is only available for a limited time
 - Mentioning the popularity of the travel products and services
 - Highlighting the features of the travel products and services
 - Converting the features into benefits, as appropriate, and recapping them
 - Discussing price with a view to making a deal
 - Mentioning that there is limited availability in travel products and services – ensure that what you say is honest and not just a statement intended to encourage purchase without reference to the truth
 - Advising any special bonuses that accompany the purchase specific travel products and services
 - Reinforcing any positive orientations that the customer has indicated with reference to the travel plans and quotation
 - Providing approved marketing materials and gifts to encourage a buying decision
 - Providing testimonials from satisfied clients
 - Supplying sample products and services, including the provision of complimentary trips to significant, large group or VIP clients.
- 
- 



Select and apply appropriate method of closing sale

In the travel industry, where you have been engaged with a customer and supplied them with advice and information, helped and suggested, assisted and recommended, then it will be likely that you will have to ask for the sale in order to reach a successful sales outcome.

Many, if not most, travel agents seem unable to do this.

It is as if they believe it is rude, too pushy or in some way inappropriate, but nothing could be further from the truth.

Asking for the sale, which is another way of saying 'closing the sale', is a key component of professional selling. It benefits the customer by finalising the process for them and allowing them to fulfil their initial intent which is to meet a want or need.

If they don't buy, their need or want remains unfilled.

The need for sensitivity

Certainly, closing a sale must be done sensitively, but it is something that nonetheless needs to be done.

You have to believe that you are not being rude, uppity or pressuring people, but acting in accordance with professional standards and ethics.

If you have performed all other aspects of providing customer service correctly, then closing the sale should be an easy and pleasurable experience. It is part of the enjoyment of selling to finalise a sale and experience the satisfaction of concluding a win-win situation.

Closing methods

There are three main closes that can be used to secure the sale.

Direct method

Probably the most common close is the direct one, where at the appropriate time you just ask for the sale.

You make a concluding remark that includes the question asking for the sale such as:

'Would you like me to secure the bookings for you?'

'Pick one' method

Where you feel that the customer prefers to stay in control of the buying decision, an alternative and effective close involves two basic steps:

- Re-presenting options
- Asking the customer to choose.

Earlier in this manual the concept of offering alternative quotation options has been discussed.

Recap method

A final version of the close is essentially a variation of the above, whereby you supply a recap of the information about the multiple options available, and then ask the closing question based on suggesting the alternative that appears to best meet the customer's stated needs.



Thanking the customer for the sale

When a sale has been made, it is essential to thank the customer.

This may come in the form of:

- Congratulating the client when they make their positive buying decision
- Thanking the client for their business
- Encouraging the client to make further purchases.



Naturally each organisation will have their own way of thanking the customer. Depending on the size of the sale this can include the provision of gifts, access to special clubs or exclusive details but to name a few suggestions.

Overcoming objections



Where your closing effort meets with resistance, you have three options, and should select on the basis of your reading of the customer and the situation.

First, you may need to redouble your sales efforts, that is, provide extra information, ask more questions to better identify needs, or start to negotiate price.

Second, give the customer some space and time to further consider their choice.

Third, if you believe the customer is adamant about their decision not to buy, you should accept their refusal gracefully and politely and continue whatever is suitable to maintain the positive customer rapport you have built during your interaction with them.

This highlights the requirement not to pressure people and accepts that not all sales will be brought to a successful conclusion despite the best (even faultless) efforts.

Whether you make a sale or not, try to learn from the experience, and identify what went right and what you probably should change next time.

4.5 Record changes to, and communications, regarding the quotation

Introduction

Once you have closed the sale, there are still many things that need to be done.

In many cases, the act of making the sale is merely the beginning of a host of activities and bookings that need to take place.

It is essential that all necessary actions taken are:

- Conducted in a timely manner
- Are recorded.

This section will explore the different activities that may take place after a sale has taken place.



Recording changes

In Sections 2.6, 2.7 and 4.1 of this manual the causes and activities associated with changes made to quotations and travel arrangements have been identified and explained.

That said, recording changes may include:

- Up-dating quotation files
- Notifying relevant other personnel and departments
- Notifying suppliers, providers and carriers, where appropriate.

Types of post-sale activities

In the absence of any changes, essential activities associated with booking travel arrangements identified in a travel quotation include, but are not limited to:

- Make the reservations
- Issue tickets and vouchers
- Final detailed itinerary
- Balance the finances, client has paid the correct amount and it has been dispersed to suppliers, wholesalers and operators.
- Check final documentation
- Flight reservations have been confirmed
- Any changes to the itinerary have been advised to the customer
- Monitor changes to file after the passenger has departed.



Communicating with past customers



Clients should be viewed as not one-off customers but lifetime clients who will return time and time again provided they receive quality service.

You should communicate with past clients on a regular basis. This communication can take many forms.

When a client returns from a trip the consultant may send a welcome-home letter or call them to see how they enjoyed the trip and to check if they were happy with the travel arrangements. They should be encouraged to tell you about their trip - both good and bad experiences. This can provide valuable feedback for future clients and possibly take the edge off what could be an aggressive complaint.

Mail outs can be used to advise clients of special offers and other travel information. Should a client refer a friend or relative to the consultant, a thank you note should be sent to the original client. Many consultants send Christmas cards to past clients thanking them for their custom throughout the year.

Many travel agencies are using computer software programs to manage lists of past clients. These programs are useful in grouping clients by destinations they have visited, products they have used or general interests. In this way information relevant to particular groups of travellers can be posted or emailed.

Summary

As can be seen in this manual, there are a wide range of activities associated with preparing and presenting quotations to customers.

Given that many travel arrangements have strong emotional attachments, they must be handled in a professional, honest yet accurate manner.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

These Work Project Activities are based on the Case Study as previously identified.

For the following Work Project Activities (4.1-4.5), the trainer will play the role of the customer. You will be required to submit the quotation to the Trainer.

4.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Advise clients of any changes to the quotation based on the customer's feedback in quotation presentation meeting.

4.2. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Explain what additional services or advise you can provide to the customer to help enhance their travel experience.

4.3. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Explain how and frequency of contact you would maintain with the customer.

4.4. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Implement actions to close the sale.

4.5 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to:

- Explain how you would record any changes to the quotation.
-

Summary

Follow-up the quotation

Advise client of any changes that will affect the provided quotation

- Contact and advise clients of changes
- Providing a revised quotation incorporating identified changes
- Highlight any new, changed or special conditions or limitations
- Filing updated quotations.

Provide additional advice and assistance, as requested

- Highlight, explain and promote features and benefits
- Promote additional products and options to enhance an itinerary
- Identify opportunities to enhance quality of service.

Maintain contact with the client

- Considerations when maintaining contact with customers
- Recording client contact conversations.

Implement actions to close the sale

- Ways to encourage a purchase
- Select and apply appropriate method of closing sale
- Closing methods
- Thanking the customer for the sale
- Overcoming objections.

Record changes to, and communications, regarding the quotation

- Recording changes
- Types of post-sale activities
- Communicating with past customers.

Presentation of written work

1. Introduction

It is important for students to present carefully prepared written work. Written presentation in industry must be professional in appearance and accurate in content. If students develop good writing skills whilst studying, they are able to easily transfer those skills to the workplace.

2. Style



Students should write in a style that is simple and concise. Short sentences and paragraphs are easier to read and understand. It helps to write a plan and at least one draft of the written work so that the final product will be well organised. The points presented will then follow a logical sequence and be relevant. Students should frequently refer to the question asked, to keep 'on track'. Teachers recognise and are critical of work that does not answer the question, or is 'padded' with irrelevant material. In summary, remember to:

- Plan ahead
- Be clear and concise
- Answer the question
- Proofread the final draft.

3. Presenting Written Work

Types of written work

Students may be asked to write:

- Short and long reports
- Essays
- Records of interviews
- Questionnaires
- Business letters
- Resumes.



Format

All written work should be presented on A4 paper, single-sided with a left-hand margin. If work is word-processed, one-and-a-half or double spacing should be used. Handwritten work must be legible and should also be well spaced to allow for ease of reading. New paragraphs should not be indented but should be separated by a space. Pages must be numbered. If headings are also to be numbered, students should use a logical and sequential system of numbering.

Cover Sheet

All written work should be submitted with a cover sheet stapled to the front that contains:

- The student's name and student number
- The name of the class/unit
- The due date of the work
- The title of the work
- The teacher's name
- A signed declaration that the work does not involve plagiarism.

Keeping a Copy

Students must keep a copy of the written work in case it is lost. This rarely happens but it can be disastrous if a copy has not been kept.

Inclusive language

This means language that includes every section of the population. For instance, if a student were to write 'A nurse is responsible for the patients in her care at all times' it would be implying that all nurses are female and would be excluding male nurses.

Examples of appropriate language are shown on the right:

Mankind	<i>Humankind</i>
Barman/maid	<i>Bar attendant</i>
Host/hostess	<i>Host</i>
Waiter/waitress	<i>Waiter or waiting staff</i>

Recommended reading

Bhatia, A; 2012 (1st edition); *The Business of Travel Agency & Tour Operations Management*; Sterling Publishers

Davidoff, Doris & Phillip; 1995 (3rd edition); *Air Fares and Ticketing*; Prentice Hall

Mears, Lee; 2012 (1st edition); *How to Become a Travel Agent*; CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform

Pelentay, Lori; 2013 (1st edition); *How to Sell Cruises Step-by-Step: A Beginner's Guide to Becoming a "Cruise-Selling" Travel Agent*; CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform

Purzycki, Jeanne; 2000 (3rd edition); *Practical Guide to Fares & Ticketing*; Cengage Learning

Rastogi, K; 2007 (1st edition); *Air Travel Ticketing and Fare Construction Hardcover*; Aman Publications

Singh, K; 2008 (1st edition); *Foreign Exchange Management and Air Ticketing Hardcover*; Isha Books

Smith, Patrick; 2013 (1st edition); *Cockpit Confidential: Everything You Need to Know About Air Travel*; Sourcebooks

Trainee evaluation sheet

Prepare and submit quotations

The following statements are about the competency you have just completed.

Please tick the appropriate box	Agree	Don't Know	Do Not Agree	Does Not Apply
There was too much in this competency to cover without rushing.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most of the competency seemed relevant to me.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The competency was at the right level for me.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I got enough help from my trainer.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The amount of activities was sufficient.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The competency allowed me to use my own initiative.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My training was well-organised.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My trainer had time to answer my questions.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I understood how I was going to be assessed.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I was given enough time to practice.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My trainer feedback was useful.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Enough equipment was available and it worked well.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The activities were too hard for me.	☐	☐	☐	☐

The best things about this unit were:

The worst things about this unit were:

The things you should change in this unit are:

Trainee self-assessment checklist

As an indicator to your Trainer/Assessor of your readiness for assessment in this unit please complete the following and hand to your Trainer/Assessor.

Prepare and submit quotations

		Yes	No*
Element 1: Identify the context for the quotation			
1.1	Identify the focus for quotations	☐	☐
1.2	Identify the details for the quotation	☐	☐
1.3	Error! Reference source not found.	☐	☐
Element 2: Prepare the quotation			
2.1	Establish files to record the quotation	☐	☐
2.2	Identify appropriate supplier and provider alternatives	☐	☐
2.3	Calculate costs of products and services required for the quotation	☐	☐
2.4	Identify terms and conditions that apply to the quotation	☐	☐
2.5	Submit draft quotation for approval	☐	☐
2.6	Amend draft quotation, as required	☐	☐
2.7	Record and file the approved quotation	☐	☐
Element 3: Submit the quotation			
3.1	Identify the required submission method	☐	☐
3.2	Provide the quotation	☐	☐
3.3	Explain and expand on the quotation	☐	☐
3.4	Encourage questions from the client	☐	☐
3.5	Advise client of action to make booking	☐	☐

		Yes	No*
Element 4: Follow-up the quotation			
4.1	Advise client of any changes that will affect the provided quotation	☐	☐
4.2	Provide additional advice and assistance, as requested	☐	☐
4.3	Maintain contact with the client	☐	☐
4.4	Implement actions to close the sale	☐	☐
4.5	Record changes to, and communications, regarding the quotation	☐	☐

Statement by Trainee:

I believe I am ready to be assessed on the following as indicated above:

Signed: _____

Date: _____

Note:

For all boxes where a **No*** is ticked, please provide details of the extra steps or work you need to do to become ready for assessment.

